



ACT AMENDED

Govt. expands ambit of drug-tracing framework

NEWS » PAGE 14

FIFA WORLD CUP

Brazil routs Scotland, moves into knockouts

SPORT » PAGE 17



RAM TEMPLE

FIR filed against eight persons in donation row

NEWS » PAGE 13



PARLEY

A maritime flashpoint

Should Indian seafarers stop serving on sanctioned ships?

OPINION » PAGE 11



WOMEN'S T20 WORLD CUP

Radha and Shafali star in India's win

SPORT » PAGE 18



NEARBY



'My act of giving student first aid misrepresented'

188 dead, 1,500 injured as earthquakes hit Venezuela

'Doublet earthquake', with an initial 7.2 magnitude tremor closely followed by a stronger 7.5 one, wreaks havoc in the South American country; tremors felt in neighbouring Colombia and Brazil

Agence France-Presse
LA GUAIRA

A pair of powerful earthquakes that rocked Venezuela have killed at least 188 people and left more than 1,500 hurt, officials said on Thursday as residents searched for loved ones trapped under rubble after many buildings were flattened within minutes.

An international outpouring of aid quickly followed the tremors on Wednesday evening, which the United States Geological Survey (USGS) measured as magnitude 7.2 and 7.5, centred west of the capital Caracas. Tremors from the earthquakes were also felt in neighbouring Colombia and Brazil.

Interim President Delcy Rodriguez said that intense



Lost in seconds: A woman holds a boy near a collapsed building in Caracas, Venezuela, on Thursday following the earthquakes. AFP

rescue efforts were going on, noting that the State of La Guaira was hit hard.

"Dozens of buildings have collapsed, and we are currently carrying out very intense rescue efforts to save as many lives as God allows us to save," Ms. Rodriguez said on state televi-

sion on Thursday. "La Guaira State is a true tragedy, and has become a disaster zone."

The first earthquake, with an epicentre 21 kilometres west of the coastal town of Moron, occurred at 6.04 p.m. local time on Wednesday, the USGS said.

Within a minute, a 7.5-magnitude earthquake struck about 45 kilometres away. They struck at depths of 22 kilometres and 10 kilometres, respectively.

Scores of rescuers from the U.S. and several European countries and UN specialists were on their way to help search for survivors, Ms. Rodriguez said while nations including China, India, Brazil, and war-battered Iran offered help. However, threatening to complicate the relief effort, the international airport near Caracas was closed due to "serious damage," Ms. Rodriguez said, with social media videos showing the terminal's ceiling collapsing over panicked travellers.

CONTINUED ON
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3 States close ranks on Tungabhadra basin



Joining hands: Chief Ministers D.K. Shivakumar, N. Chandrababu Naidu, and A. Revanth Reddy share a stage on Thursday. ANI

Kumar Buradikatti
KALABURAGI

Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, and Telangana on Thursday signalled a "historic" consensus on protecting the interests of farmers in the Tungabhadra basin and pursuing long-term solutions to irrigation and water-sharing issues.

At an event organised by the Karnataka government and the Tungabhadra Board in Koppal district to mark the inauguration of

the newly installed 33 spillway gates of the reservoir in Vijayanagara, Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar and his Telangana and Andhra Pradesh counterparts, A. Revanth Reddy and N. Chandrababu Naidu, stressed the need for cooperation in addressing the concerns of lakhs of farmers dependent on the inter-State project.

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CENTRE PROPOSES PANEL
» PAGE 9

Govt. restores commercial LPG supply to pre-war level

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

The Centre on Thursday restored the supply of industrial and commercial liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) to pre-war levels and withdrew all sector-specific allocation caps that had been imposed at the peak of the West Asia crisis, citing an improved supply situation.

In addition to this, bulk LPG consumers will be allotted 50% of their pre-crisis consumption requirements. Supplies had been suspended at the onset of the crisis. The government also eased its earlier direction mandating that propane and butane – used in other sectors as well – be only used for domestic LPG production.

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» PAGE 12
TRANSIT ROUTE DISPUTE
» PAGE 15

CBI searches 80 locations, nabs 2 over 'digital arrests'

Devesh K. Pandey
NEW DELHI

In a crackdown on the cybercrime infrastructure facilitating "digital arrest" scams, the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) searched more than 80 locations across the country over the past week in connection with 200-plus cases. It has arrested two accused so far – Naresh from Chennai, Tamil Nadu, and Sanjib Saha of Kolkata, West Bengal.

Under Operation Chakra-VI, the agency formed 60 special teams and conducted coordinated searches in Punjab, Gujarat, Delhi, Maharashtra, Haryana, Tamil Nadu, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh,

The Central agency conducted searches in locations linked to more than 200 cases in 15 States and Delhi

Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, Assam, West Bengal, Manipur, Karnataka, and Odisha.

"The searches were carried out as part of an ongoing investigation aimed at dismantling a targeted operational network involved in over 200 cases of digital arrest scams," said the agency.

The arrested accused were involved in the incorporation of shell companies and the opening and

operation of mule bank accounts. These accounts were used for laundering about ₹2 crore of suspected proceeds of crime, the CBI said.

Fraudulent website Recently, the agency unearthed a fraudulent website with a URL deceptively similar to the official website of the Supreme Court. The fraudsters allegedly used the registered domain to defraud victims. Based on a complaint received from the Registry of the Supreme Court, the agency registered a case and launched an investigation.

CONTINUED ON
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T.N. Electricity Dept. debt is ₹2.47 lakh cr., says Minister

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Presenting a White Paper on the Tamil Nadu Electricity Department, Electricity Minister R. Nirmalkumar said the Tamil Nadu Power Distribution Corporation Limited, the Tamil Nadu Power Generation Corporation Limited, the Tamil Nadu Green Energy Corporation Limited, and the Tamil Nadu Transmission Corporation Limited had sustained heavy losses, with the total debt of the four corporations standing at ₹2.47 lakh crore.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 8

DVAC books ex-Minister E.V. Velu in alleged corruption case; launches raids across T.N.

S. Vijay Kumar
CHENNAI

In the first major crackdown after the TVK came to power, the Directorate of Vigilance and Anti-Corruption (DVAC) launched simultaneous searches on the premises of former State Highways Minister E.V. Velu, officials, and contractors in connection with an alleged corruption case.

Acting on a 2022 complaint by Jayaram Venkatesan of Arappor Iyakkam, an NGO fighting corruption, the agency booked Mr. Velu, several officials of the Highways Department, and a highways contractor on charges of criminal conspiracy, forgery, and cheating, and invoked provi-



DVAC personnel at the residence of former State Highways Minister E.V. Velu in Chennai on Thursday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

sions under the Prevention of Corruption Act, 1988. The case was registered after the State government accorded permission on June 23, 2026.

The allegation is that several crores of rupees

had been paid to contractors in various divisions of the State Highways Department in March 2022 for works that were not executed until then. This happened in collusion with officials of the State

Highways Department and a select set of Highways contractors.

The complainant alleged that there was rampant corruption and mismanagement of funds allocated under the Comprehensive Road Infrastructure Development Programme.

In the Tiruppur circle, of the sanctioned amount of ₹4.19 crore for widening and improvement of roads, ₹3.23 crore was paid without any work actually being done. After former AIADMK Minister M.R. Vijayabaskar filed a complaint on April 5, 2022, four officials were suspended.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 8



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INBRIEF



Sri Ramachandra Medical Centre gets Pelvic Health Clinic

A ‘Pelvic Health Clinic’ was inaugurated at the Sri Ramachandra Medical Centre on Thursday to promote specialised care for pelvic floor disorders and mark World Continence Week. The clinic was inaugurated by Sonali Santharam, founder of Birth Basix, in the presence of SRIHER trustee Samyuktha Venkataachalam. Dr. Sonali said continence-related disorders often go untreated because of stigma, misconceptions, and lack of awareness. Vice-Chancellor Uma Sekar, Pro-Vice-Chancellor Mahesh Vakamudi, Principal of the Faculty of Physiotherapy P. Antony Leo Aseer, faculty members and students took part in the event, the release added.

MoU signed to promote semiconductor research

A Memorandum of Understanding was signed between Chennai Institute of Technology, National Formosa University, and AGEM Technology to promote semiconductor research, talent development, and industry-academia collaboration. This trilateral initiative is among the first-of-its-kind between Taiwan and South India in the semiconductor sector, establishing a framework for joint research, training, and innovation-driven cooperation. A press release said the Taipei Economic and Cultural Center in Chennai unveiled an official office plaque on Thursday to commemorate its 14th anniversary. The unveiling ceremony was jointly officiated by Stephen S.C. Hsu, Director-General, and Vijayakumar, Head of the Ministry of External Affairs Branch Secretariat in Chennai.

Smart traffic system set to be launched by August, says official

As part of the ₹530-cr. Chennai Intelligent Transport Systems project, the city will get adaptive traffic signals and detection cameras for road safety

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The ₹530-crore Chennai Intelligent Transport Systems (ITS) project, funded by the Japan International Cooperation Agency, is expected to be fully operational by August, with infrastructure being installed across major roads and junctions in the city.

The aim is to improve traffic management, road safety, and public transport services through advanced technology.

Additional Chief Secretary of the Municipal Administration and Water Supply Department Gagan-deep Singh Bedi inspected the ongoing work near the Egmore signal on Poonamallee High Road on Thursday.

Officials were told to ensure that all major components were commissioned within the scheduled timeline, a press release said.

The project comprises two major categories: the Traffic Information and Management System for the Greater Chennai Traffic Police and the City Bus System for the Metropolitan Transport Corporation.

As part of the rollout,



Gagandeep Singh Bedi, Additional Chief Secretary, Municipal Administration and Water Supply, inspecting the ongoing work near the Egmore signal on Poonamallee High Road on Thursday.

165 adaptive traffic control signals, 50 red-light violation detection systems, 10 speed-limit violation detection systems, 58 traffic incident detection systems, and 115 automatic traffic count and classification units are being installed across the city, the release added.

Real-time updates

The project also includes an integrated command and control centre for the traffic police, 13 variable message signboards providing real-time traffic updates, and an MTC command centre.

About 3,500 buses are being fitted with Automatic Vehicle Location System (AVLS) devices, while 616

passenger information display boards and 32 depot management systems are being installed to modernise bus operations.

Permissions for establishing communication network infrastructure have been obtained from the Chennai Corporation and the State Highways Department, while power connections and junction improvement works are progressing well.

Once operational, the ITS project is expected to reduce travel and waiting times, improve traffic flow, strengthen automated traffic enforcement, and improve the reliability of public transport services across the city, the release added.



Improving access: Minister P. Venkataramanan flagging off the vehicle at Kauvery Hospital on Thursday. M. SRINATH

Kauvery Hospital launches mobile mammogram unit

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Kauvery Hospital on Thursday launched a mobile mammogram unit to improve access to early breast cancer screening for women.

Minister of Food and Civil Supplies P. Venkataramanan, who flagged off the vehicle, raised the need to create awareness of cancer screening among women.

The mobile unit was a Corporate Social Responsibility initiative undertaken in association with Lions Club of Chennai, KVG Charitable Trust, Lions District 3241 C.

Aravindan Selvaraj, co-founder and executive director, Kauvery Hospital, said the vehicle, which is slightly bigger than an ambulance, will provide screening at the doorstep. A women-led service, it will have women doctors and radiologists on board. “Women’s health is largely ignored. They do not come

forward for breast examination, mammograms, and cervical pap smears due to privacy concerns. Complications are mainly due to late diagnosis of breast cancers,” he said.

Kavitha Sundaravadanam, senior family physician, said many women were unwilling to undergo breast screening and mammogram, and skipped health check-ups. Some also fear mammograms, she said, stressing the need for breast cancer screening once in two years and pap smear once in three years. Sujay Susikar, senior consultant, Surgical Oncology and Robotic Surgeon spoke.

S. Bose, District Governor-3241 C, Lions International; K.V. Gopalakrishnan, chairman, Lions Club of Chennai, KVG Charitable Trust; Iyappan Ponnuswamy, medical director, Kauvery Hospital; and Mahesh Kumar, medical superintendent, Kauvery Hospital, were present.

250 years of American Independence celebrated

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The U.S. Ambassador to India Sergio Gor celebrated 250 years of American independence at the U.S. Consulate General’s National Day event held earlier this week.

Public Works Minister Aadhav Arjuna and Consul General Mariana L. Neisuler spoke on the potential for stronger bilateral cooperation in strategic technologies, engineering, and sports.

Ambassador Gor said the embassy was prepared to work with individuals across India to advance this relationship.

The event featured musical performances by the Brass Ensemble of the A.R. Rahman Foundation’s “Sunshine Orchestra” and Alisha Mathew Thayil.

Timings

CHENNAI		
FRIDAY, JUN. 26		
RISE	05:46	SET 18:39
RISE	15:44	SET 02:32
SATURDAY, JUN. 27		
RISE	05:46	SET 18:39
RISE	16:36	SET 03:17
SUNDAY, JUN. 28		
RISE	05:46	SET 18:39
RISE	17:29	SET 04:04

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Chennai Airport	37	29
Chennai City	37	28

Chennai Airport Today
38°C The weather will be slightly hot and uneasy. Night also will be uneasy. Spell of light rain and thundershower may occur.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
37°C Morning will be comfortable. Day will be very warm and uneasy. Chances of light rain and thundershower. Night also will be uneasy.

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CINEMA ♦ ARTS ♦ EVENTS

MUSIC DANCE DRAMA

The Music Academy Madras
Today: At the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall 6.00 p.m. to 7.30 p.m. – S.M. Subhani (Mandolin), V.V. Ravi (Violin), Parupalli Pavalu (Mridangam) – Programme under the endowment instituted by the family of Sri. Dwaram in memory of Sangita Kalandihi Sri. Dwaram Venkataswamy Naidu.

The Music Academy Madras
Tomorrow from 10.00 a.m. to 12 Noon at the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall – Violin Centric Workshop – Mula Abhyasa at Music Academy – Violin Fundamentals and Practice Techniques – by Embar S Kannan – Registration – Rs. 50/- Students and rasikas welcome. Contact Music Academy Office – 2811231/2811562. Programme under the endowment instituted by the family of Sri. Dwaram in memory of Sangita Kalandihi Sri. Dwaram Venkataswamy Naidu.

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Kartik Fine Arts,
Ph: 24997788/9840928049
Today 5.30pm at Kartik Rajagopal Hall (A/C), 3/2, Sringeri Mutt Road, (Opp. Mandaveli Railway Station), R.A. Puram, Chennai 28, G.K. Baanupriya (Vocal) – Naveen (Violin) – Ajeet Sridhar (Mridangam) 7pm Hemmige S. Prashanth (Vocal) – Sudha R.S. Iyer (Violin) – B.R. Srinivas (Mridangam). All are welcome.

Naada Inbam, 24992672
Today 6.15pm Mylapore & Triplicane – Music from the ancient twin towns’ by Carnatic twins Archana & Aarathi, Bombay Madhavan, B. Ganapathiraman, Hari Kishore. Concert dedicated to Smt Andal & Sri V. Ananthanarayanan. Ragasudha Hall.

Narada Gana Sabha,

Phone: 24993201

Today Main Hall (Sathguru Gnanananda Hall) 6.45 pm – Drama – Prasiddhi Creation’s ‘Yagavaraayinam’ by Ambi Raghavan. Direction – RAGI (Ambi Raghavan & Girish Venkat) Tickets at the Hall. For Music Class details contact Sabha Office.

Pushpanjali Cultural Trust
Today 5.30pm at R.K. Swamy auditorium mylapore Bharathanayam Kum. KEERTHANA KATHIRVEL (Dis. of Sri. S. Herambanathan) 7pm Bharathanayam by Kum. Harithra Madhu & Kum. Akshita Vinod (Dis. of Smt. Meenakshi Chitharanjan).

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I, **J. JAYALAKSHMI**, wife of R. JANARDHANAN, aged 61 years, residing at No:18, Bharathi Road 2nd Street, Perambur, Chennai 600011. My Husband Name has been incorrectly Mentioned in my Passport as Janardhanan, the Correct Spelling is Janardhanan.

I, Purna Bahadur, S/o Krishna Bahadur DOB: 31/05/1989 Address: Plot no 2, Chathiram 1st Street, Veppampattu, Tiruvallur, Tamil Nadu - 602024. Shall henceforth be known as Purna Bahadur - Purna Bahadur

I, Bhupendra Bahadur Purna Bahadur, S/o Purna Bahadur, DOB: 14/07/1992, Address: Plot no 2, Chathiram 1st Street, Veppampattu, Tiruvallur, Tamil Nadu-602024. Shall henceforth be known as Bhupendra Bahadur Purna Bahadur - Bhupendra Bahadur Purna Bahadur.

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PUBLIC ANNOUNCEMENT

ENROLMENT NOTICE

After ten days of the publication of this notice and with in THREE months thereafter I, **SOWMINI PRIYA S**, D/o.SUBRAMANIAN A, aged 36 years Residing at F2, first floor, Dhanalakshmi flats, Plot no 24, Maharajapuram Main Street, Santhosapuram, Vengaiwasal, Kancheepuram - 600073, intend having my enrolment as an advocate moved before the Bar Council Buildings, High Court Campus, Chennai-104. Those who have any valid objections may Notify the same to the Bar Council within 10 days.
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VACANT LAND for RENT/LEASE 1 Ground – 1 acre Perumbakkam Main Road 9841048247

1100SQ.FT SHOP for Rent Global Hospital main road Perumbakkam Main Road 9841048247

PREMIUM 3413-SO.FT. Plug-and-Play Office Space in Egmore, Chennai. Fully furnished with 37 Work Stations., Exec. Cabins, Conf. Room, 24x7 Pwr.Bkp., 4 covered Car Parks, and ample free parking. Prestigious business address with excellent connectivity. Ideal for MNCs, IT/ITES, GCCs, consulting firms, and corporateoffices. Ct: 9384828103.

NUNGAMBAKKAM 1000SQFT Commercial Property for Rent. Contact: 9884324366

VELACHERY TERMINUS 2400 Sft+ 1400 Sft Open type Toilet Area 600 Sft, 3rd Floor, 3 Phase,Lift, GF Parking,Generator Backup 9844038460

BUILD-TO-SUIT : land 33.000 Sq.ft. avbl, 100 metres from Radial Road & behind Dr. Kamakshi Hospital Pallikaranai.Cosmic Properties 9047734343

NEAR MOUNTROAD Ground/First/Second Floor Rent 9941473000, 9381000999

3BHK 1100SQFT 1st Floor Covered Car Park Call: 9444820332 / 9444820332

NEELA NAGAR Compact 2BHK FF CCP Rs.14K Ct: 96854 92253 / 9940261166

MYLAPORE
MYLAPORE SAI Baba Koil Narasimhapuram 2BHK, CP, GF 40K. Ct: 9444165153

VIRUGAMBAKKAM
NR.BALALOK SCH GF-2BHK-23K,5F-3BHK-CCP-42K,Lift,Only Family. 9159914150

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9 June 1924 – 19 June 2026



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Thank you for over a century of unconditional love,
compassion and wisdom. We will honor your legacy as you
continue to guide and inspire us forever.



THE RAMAMOORTHY FAMILY

From Page One

DVAC books E.V. Velu in ‘corruption’ case; launches raids in T.N.

The action was said to have been taken on the basis of a report of the Superintending Engineer that the payment was made without laying the road.

However, instead of proceeding with criminal action for the offence, Mr. Venkatesan alleged that a battalion of policemen was brought in as bandobast for the contractor to lay the roads on April 8, 2022. “The Karur police, instead of acting on the criminals, are said to have provided them with security to lay roads without any disturbance. This is a gross attempt towards erasing evidence of criminal acts committed by the officials of State Highways Department and contractor Sankaranand Infra with respect to the swindling of the exchequer’s money,” the complainant said.

Arappor Iyakkam pointed to similar offences in other parts of the State and gave evidence to substantiate the same. It demanded that a case be registered against all those concerned, and suitable action be taken.

The DVAC, in its FIR, said *prima facie* materials in the petition revealed that the accused persons had entered into a criminal conspiracy with a dishonest intention to cheat the government.

Besides Mr. Velu, the agency named nine officials of the Highways Department who worked in Karur, Coimbatore, Tiruchi, and Chennai, and Highways contractor Sankaran Infra.

The DVAC, in a statement issued on Thursday evening, said that searches were conducted at 20 places across the State, which included the residences and offices belonging to Mr. Velu.

During the searches, valuable documents, digital evidences, documents related to the Highways Department, and other incriminating documents were seized, the statement said. The DVAC said unaccounted money to the tune of ₹40 lakh was seized during the entire operation.

Mr. Velu, however, said that no money was seized from any premises belonging to him.

Among the premises searched in Karur were the house of M.C. Shankar Anand, the PWD contractor and a close friend of former Minister V. Senthilbalaji on Palaniappa Street; the house of A. Rafeeq Mohamed at Pallapatti, who works as an Assistant Divisional Engineer at the office of Chief Engineer, Planning, Design and Investigation in Chennai; and the house of S. Karthik on Chinna Andankoil street, who works as Assistant Engineer at the office of Divisional Engineer, Bridge Monitoring Unit in Tiruchi.

The DVAC also conducted searches at educational institutions linked to Mr. Velu and his residence in Kilnachipattu village near Tiruvannamalai. It said the searches began around 7.30 a.m. at Arunai Group of Educational Institutions.

Velu will prove his innocence: Stalin

DMK president M.K. Stalin said Mr. Velu would extend full cooperation to the DVAC. In a post on X, he said: “Mr. E.V. Velu is extending his full cooperation to the raid conducted by the DVAC. He will face it legally and prove his innocence in court. History shows that when driven by a political vendetta, not a single charge has ever been proven in any case filed so far alleging corruption during the DMK regime. The DMK is not a movement that will be cowed by these threats from the ruling party. We have seen much greater oppression than this. We will face this too, and emerge victorious.”

INBRIEF



B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

CM flags off 300 buses, takes ride on Perambur-bound bus

Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on Thursday flagged off over 300 buses procured by various transport corporations at a cost of ₹127 crore. The new vehicles include 164 diesel buses and 136 CNG buses. Transport Minister A. Vijay Tamilan Parthiban, Chief Secretary M. Sai Kumar, and other senior officials were present on the occasion. Mr. Vijay also took a ride on a Perambur-bound bus after tendering the exact change for the ticket, officials said.

Three more deaths take toll in ammonia gas leak to 13

Three more women died on Thursday, taking the toll in the ammonia gas leak incident at a seafood processing and export facility in Tiruvallur district to 13, according to a bulletin issued by the Health Department. The victims were identified as Rita Juanga, Sumithra, and Pinki Juanga of Odisha. Currently, 43 persons – 42 women and one man – are under treatment. Of them, 14 are on ventilator support, 21 are receiving nasal oxygen, and eight are stable. A total of 27 persons have been discharged so far. The mortal remains of eight persons have been airlifted to Odisha, and the remains of two others to Assam, the bulletin said.

White Paper puts Electricity Dept. debt at ₹2.47 lakh crore

Neither Electricity Dept. nor consumers benefited from tariff revision implemented by previous government, as substantial expenditure was incurred on power purchase agreements, says report

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu will not be burdened with any tariff revision, including the annual revision of 3.57% this year, Electricity Minister R. Nirmalkumar said on Thursday.

Presenting a White Paper on the Electricity Department, he said the Tamil Nadu Power Distribution Corporation Limited (TNPDC), the Tamil Nadu Power Generation Corporation Limited (TNPGL), the Tamil Nadu Green Energy Corporation Limited (TNGECL), and the Tamil Nadu Transmission Corporation Limited (TANTRANSCO) had sustained heavy losses, with the total debt of the four corporations standing at ₹2.47 lakh crore.

The Electricity Minister said the White Paper was presented to show that the tariff revision implemented by the previous government in 2022, which led to a spike in electricity charges for all categories of consumers, benefited neither the Electricity Department nor the consumers, as substantial expenditure was incurred on power purchase agreements.

Mr. Nirmalkumar said the State, whose peak power demand was over



Electricity Minister R. Nirmalkumar releasing a White Paper on the Electricity Department in Chennai on Thursday. J. JOHAN SATHYADAS

21,300 MW, had only 3,495 MW of generation capacity from its own sources, comprising 2,965 MW of thermal power, 381 MW of hydropower, and 149 MW of gas-based power. Instead of investing in own power sources, previous governments had met the demand through electricity procured from central generating stations, solar power (at ₹6.11 per unit), long-term power purchase arrangements, and short-term power purchases, he said.

“Heavy expenses were incurred on power purchases to meet peak demand while buying from the exchange market, where prices, at times, touched ₹17 per unit,” he said.

He added that the Electricity Department had planned to save ₹215 crore in the coming years

through a new arrangement involving long- and medium-term open-access mechanisms.

Of the four major thermal power projects announced several years ago – Ennore SEZ (2x660 MW), Udangudi Stage-I (2x660 MW), ETPS Expansion (660 MW), and Uppur (2x800 MW) – only the Ennore SEZ and Udangudi projects were being implemented, he said, adding that the previous government had discontinued the other two projects after spending more than ₹8,700 crore on them, without citing any reason.

On the transmission and distribution infrastructure front, the Electricity Minister said that though good revenue was generated through the tariff revision, the previous government had failed to establish new substations.

Though 99,573 new distribution transformers were installed by the previous government, a major scam in the procurement of 45,800 distribution transformers had come to light, and the case was under investigation, he said.

Manpower shortage

The Electricity Department faces a manpower shortfall of nearly 45% of its sanctioned strength of 1,40,635 employees. The workforce stands at 74,714, leaving 65,921 vacancies. The Minister said the acute shortage of personnel in key categories, such as wiremen, linemen, and gangmen, was bound to cause delays in restoring power supply after disruptions, providing new electricity connections, and carrying out other operational works.

Mr. Nirmalkumar said he had proposed the recruitment of 15,000 personnel this year, and the absorption of 5,391 gangmen who were recruited by the previous government, but whose appointments were kept in abeyance.

He said it had been proposed to renovate 682 substations at a cost of ₹8,318 crore, expedite work on 121 substations that are under construction, and establish 231 new substations.

Amid row over his conduct, Higher Education Minister expresses regret

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Amid a political row over his conduct, Higher Education Minister P. Viswanathan on Thursday expressed regret, while insisting that his act of providing “first aid” to students during a marathon in Madurai had been misrepresented.

Mr. Viswanathan said he was shocked that ulterior motives were being attributed to his actions. “As my conduct appears to have given room for misrepresentation, I express my regret,” he said.

In a statement issued through the Tamil Nadu Congress Committee, Mr. Viswanathan referred to the recent awareness marathon organised in Madurai on the themes of drug abuse and sexual crimes against women.

‘Humanitarian concern’

Mr. Viswanathan said some students, who had participated in the 4-km run, had fainted because



As my conduct appears to have given room for misrepresentation, I express my regret
P. VISWANATHAN
Higher Education Minister

of the intense heat.

The Minister said he had stepped in to assist the affected students purely out of humanitarian concern.

“As the father of a daughter, the help I had rendered out of compassion is being portrayed with a wrong motive, which causes me deep pain,” Mr. Viswanathan added.

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on Thursday wrote to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, requesting that the Centre reconsider the proposed disinvestment of its equity in Neyveli Lignite Corporation (NLC) India Limited.

“The Government of Tamil Nadu strongly opposes,

in principle, any further dilution of the Government of India’s equity in NLC India Limited. This issue is of special significance to Tamil Nadu, as NLC India is intrinsically linked to the State through its origin, growth, and continuing operations,” Mr. Vijay said in his letter.

NLC India is not merely a listed company, but a strategic national asset en-

gaged in energy security, mineral development, and critical infrastructure, he said. “Any further dilution of the Government of India’s equity, however limited, sets an undesirable precedent in respect of public ownership of such strategically significant enterprises. It also raises concerns that extend beyond financial considerations and touch upon the long-

term interests of the State, its people, and the nation’s energy security,” he added.

Tamil Nadu had consistently maintained that the Government of India’s shareholding in NLC India should not be reduced further, Mr. Vijay said.

“Public sector enterprises of this nature, particularly those established and expanded with the sus-

Report ‘conveniently ignored’ DMK govt’s efforts: Senthilbalaji

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Countering the White Paper released by Electricity Minister R. Nirmalkumar, former Minister for Electricity V. Senthilbalaji said it was the previous DMK government that saved the Electricity Department.

“The demand for electricity increases every year. Though the demand kept rising over the past five years, we provided uninterrupted and uniform supply. During the earlier AIADMK regime, the electricity tariff was hiked thrice – by 37%, 3.5%, and 16%. Even with those tariff hikes, the revenue deficit soared to the range of ₹56,000 crore to ₹58,000 crore. However, over the last five years, the gap between revenue and expenditure was reduced to ₹34,447 crore,” he said.

Furthermore, by lowering the interest rates on loans taken by the electricity board, ₹1,200 crore - ₹1,500 crore was saved per year, and the revenue generated from the sale of fly ash obtained from thermal power stations rose to around ₹160 crore, he said.

When the DMK assumed office in 2021, the total debt of the Tamil Nadu Electricity Board stood at ₹1,59,731 crore, with around ₹15,000 crore being paid towards interest for just a single year, he said. He added that in the last five years, ₹75,000 crore had been paid solely in interest. Power generation costs, electricity procurement costs, and transmission charges had also increased over the past five years, he said.

Asserting that electricity was never procured at inflated prices, he said power generation capacity had been increased by 9,000 MW during the last five years.

“When we came to power, projects such as the Kundah project and the Kolli Hills project were in their initial stages. We completed a significant portion of the work on them,” he said, adding that a staff shortage should not be cited as a reason for the current electricity issues.

Pointing out that Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay recently distributed appointment orders to 401 individuals in the Electricity Department, Mr. Senthilbalaji said all of them were selected during the DMK regime.

The increase in electricity consumption by the industries was not mentioned in the White Paper, he added.

Velumani, Viswanathan appointed as deputy general secretaries of AIADMK

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami on Thursday announced new party positions for former rebel leaders, including S.P. Velumani and Natham Viswanathan. The two leaders, who were among those who rebelled against Mr. Palaniswami after the Assembly poll, were appointed deputy general secretaries of the party.

Mr. Palaniswami had earlier stripped the dissidents of their posts. A total of 25 MLAs had defied the party whip and voted in favour of the government led by Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay in a trust vote in the Assembly. However, all of them later reconciled with Mr. Palaniswami and accepted his leadership.

Varagur A. Arunachalam has been appointed as the party headquarters secretary, while former Ministers P. Thangamani, K.C. Karuppannan, S.P. Shanmuganathan, K.P. Anbalagan, R. Kamaraj, K.C. Veeramani and P. Balakrishna Reddy, Tiruttani Go. Hari, C. Krishna Murali, R.P. Marutharaja, and P. Soundararajan have been appointed as organising secretaries.

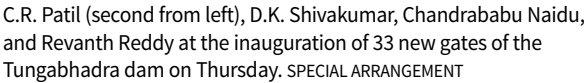
Former Ministers M.R. Vijayabhaskar and M. Manikandan have been appointed as joint propaganda secretaries. For the Anna Thozhirsanga Peravai (labour wing), ATC Pon. Dhanabalan has been appointed as president, and Bell R. Thamilarasan as secretary. Former Minister Pollachi Jayaraman has been posted as the Coimbatore Suburban South district secretary. Former Minister V. Saroja has been posted as the party’s Medical Wing secretary.

Paper leaks show systemic failure in NTA, says Minister

He also claimed paper leaks and irregularities in five major examinations – NEET-UG, JEE, UPSC, SSC and Railway Recruitment Board tests – had affected 6.54 crore candidates in the past decade.

The committee has been proposed for finding a permanent solution to water-related problems between Telangana, A.P. and Karnataka; Revanth says his govt. will offer full cooperation to panel

He was speaking at a public meeting convened in



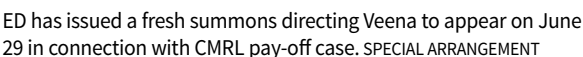
nister N. Chandrababu Naidu and Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar.

Mr. Reddy described the event as historic and expressed hope that Mr. Patil, reputed as a problem

“We are hopeful that the Union Government will find a lasting solution to the problem,” Mr. Reddy said.

The agency summoned her for questioning after it obtained copies of 134 documents collected by the Serious Fraud Investigation Office (SFIO), which had investigated the al-

Following her initial round of questioning, the ED had inspected Ms. Vee-na's bank lockers in Thiruvananthapuram on June 19. Subsequently, the agency issued a fresh summons directing her to appear on June 29 in connection with the money-laundering



probe in the CMRL pay-off case. However, Thursday's questioning appears to have been prompted by the receipt of documents from the SFIO.

A special court in Ernakulam had earlier permitted the Central agency to access the SFIO's documents, which related to alleged fictitious expenses submit-

The Foreign Contribution Regulation Act (FCRA), which emerged as a key political flashpoint in central Travancore, Kerala, during the recent Assembly election, appears poised

The first salvo came on Thursday from the Malankara Orthodox Syrian Church, which questioned the requirement that FCRA account holders furnish details of their social media accounts and publications.

The Church warned against what it sees as an attempt to widen regulatory scrutiny beyond financial transaction, also raised concerns over the manner in which the revised regulations were introduced, maintaining that stakeholders to be consulted.

Government of Jharkhand
Department of Industries
3rd Floor, Napat House, Doranda, Ranchi- 834002

Request for Proposal (RFP) for the Selection of Event Management Firm for Design, Erection, Decoration, Maintenance & Management of both interior and exterior of 'JHARKHAND PAVILION' at 'BHARAT TEX' 2026 from 14th to 17th July 2026 at Bharati Mandapam, New Delhi

Tender Ref. No. -1502 dated- 24.06.2026
 Directorate of Industries, Department of Industries,
 Government of Jharkhand invites technical and financial proposals from reputed management consultancy firms of national and international repute to work as an Event Management Agency for Design, Erection, Decoration, Maintenance & Management of both interior and exterior of 'JHARKHAND PAVILION' at 'BHARAT TEX' 2026 from 14th to 17th July 2026 at Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi. The document can be downloaded from the website: [**https://jharkhandtenders.gov.in/nicgp/ep**](https://jharkhandtenders.gov.in/nicgp/ep)

Response to this tender shall be deemed to have been done after careful study and examination of this document with full understanding of its implications. This section provides general information about the Issuer, important dates and addresses and the overall eligibility criteria for the parties.

Notice for Inviting Tender

Information Sheet		
S. No.	Particulars	Details
1	Publishing of RFP/ Tender on website	25 June, 2026
2	Period of downloading and Submission of tender	Start date: 26 June, 2026 to End date: 03 July 2026, 3:00 PM
3	Last date for receiving queries	28 June, 2026
4	Response to queries	29 June, 2026
5	Technical proposal opening	06 July 2026, 12.00 PM
6	Presentation on approach & methodology	07 July 2026, 11:30 AM
7	Method of Selection (QCBS)	70:30
8	Financial Bid Opening	To be notified
9	Cost of Tender	INR 10,000/- (Online at e-tender portal)
10	Earnest Money Deposit (EMD)	INR 1,00,000/- (Rupees One Lakh only to be deposited online at e-tender portal)
11	Website for downloading Tender Documents and Submitting Proposals	https://jharkhandtenders.gov.in/nicgp/ep
12	Mode of submission of Tender	Online only
13	Contact Details	Directorate of Industries, Nepal House, Doranda, Ranchi, Jharkhand 834002 Email: jhr-doi@nic.in

For any clarification, please contact: **Sh. Lalit Kumar**, Under Secretary, Directorate of Industries, Contact No. 9934706606. The undersigned reserves the right to reject, cancel any particular or all bid offer without assigning any reason whatsoever. The decision of the undersigned shall be final and binding.

Sd/-
Director of Industries
Govt. of Jharkhand



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Date: 25.06.2026

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

Tenders are invited by **KS&DL** in two cover system through Karnataka Public Procurement Portal (Website <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in/>) with respect to supply of following Goods/Services/Works.

Sl. No.	Tender Number	Tender Name	Tender Quantity	Published date	Last Date of Submission
1	KSDL/2026-27/OW/WORK_INDENT45	Interior works for new KSDL branch office at Vijayawada	Works	24-06-2026	09-07-2026
2	KSDL/2026-27/SE0248	Disposal of waste corrugated boxes at KSDL, Bengaluru Complex on AS IS WHERE IS BASIS	Services	24-06-2026	09-07-2026
3	KSDL/2026-27/IND1281	Procurement of Sandal Bath Tablet 150g (S) Corrugated Boxes	100000 Nos.	24-06-2026	01-07-2026
4	KSDL/2026-27/SE0249	Renewal of Fire, Burglary, and Miscellaneous Insurance Policies covering a total Sum Insured of Rs.1,150 Crores on a Declaration Basis for the period from 20 July 2026 to 19 July 2027.	Services	24-06-2026	08-07-2026
5	KSDL/2026-27/IND1282	Procurement of Yara Yara	4000 Kgs	25-06-2026	03-07-2026
6	KSDL/2026-27/IND1280	Procurement of Sandalwood Oil	2000 Kgs	25-06-2026	02-07-2026

For any further queries/clarifications please contact the undersigned.

Sd/- Asst. General Manager (Materials)

Five drown in Cauvery in Karnataka's Muthathi

Superintendent of Mandya district police V.J. Shobha Rani said the four women ignored the warning given by the home guards at the spot against venturing into the waters.

WEATHER WATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday

TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: AQICN/CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 17.45 HRS)

Forecast for Friday: Heavy/very heavy rainfall likely at isolated places over Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Meghalaya, Manipur, Tripura, Sikkim, West Bengal, Bihar, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh, central Maharashtra, Konkan & Goa and Karnataka. Heat wave to severe heat wave conditions likely at isolated places over east Uttar Pradesh

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala		33.3	27.2	Kurnool		37.6	26.8
Ahmedabad		40.5	29.0	Lucknow		39.9	30.0
Aizawl	0.1	28.5	23.4	Madurai		40.5	26.2
Bengaluru		30.5	20.8	Mangaluru	22.8	29.0	23.8
Bhopal	38	32.8	22.0	Mumbai	13.4	32.2	24.5
Bhubaneswar		37.2	26.1	Mysuru		30.4	20.0
Chandigarh		38.5	26.2	New Delhi	2.2	38.8	25.2
Chennai		39.6	29.2	Patna		40.8	30.7
Coimbatore		33.4	23.0	Port Blair	0.3	31.5	26.7
Dehradun	4.2	36.1	24.2	Prayagraj		43.0	29.5
Gangtok	2.5	25.0	18.4	Puducherry		38.3	27.6
Gwalior	92.6	32.0	23.8	Pune	4.7	31.8	23.4
Guwahati	37.6	34.8	24.6	Raipur		38.0	27.6
Hubbali		28.0	20.3	Ranchi	15.0	32.7	23.0
Hyderabad		41.7	24.2	Shillong	11.2	25.6	16.4
Imphal	5.8	32.1	22.4	Shimla	5.3	27.8	19.5
Jaipur	1.2	37.0	28.9	Srinagar		30.8	18.3
Kochi	2	31.2	26.4	Thiruvananthapuram		32.0	26.4
Kohima		25.0	19.0	Tiruchirappalli		39.1	26.6
Kolkata		36.7	28.6	Vijayawada	1.8	36.0	26.0
Kozhikode	4.1	34.0	25.9	Visakhapatnam		33.9	29.0

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Pollutants in the air you are breathing

CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM2.5	PM10	CODE
Ahmedabad	—	—	—			
Bengaluru	—	—	—			
Chennai	—	—	—			
Delhi	12	39	18	112	182	■
Hyderabad	—	—	—			
Kolkata	—	—	—			
Lucknow	—	—	—			
Mumbai	—	—	—			
Pune	—	—	—			
Visakhapatnam	—	—	—			

Yesterday

In observation made at 4.00 p.m., Bahadurgarh, Haryana recorded an overall air quality index (AQI) score of 263 indicating an unhealthy level of pollution. In contrast, Aizawl, Mizoram recorded a healthy AQI score of 21

Air Quality Code: ■ Poor ■ Moderate ■ Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

So₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, causing breathing difficulty. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.

No₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.

CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

PM2.5 & PM10: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease



BENGALURU NORTH CITY CORPORATION

Office of the Executive Engineer, Zone-1, Vidyanarayana Division,
No. 582, 1st Main BEL Layout, 2nd Stage, Vidyanarayana, Bengaluru - 560097.

No: BNCC/EE/WD-P/KPPP/03/2026-27
Date: 25-06-2026

SHORT TERM TENDER NOTIFICATION

(Two Cover System) (Through GOK Karnataka Public Procurement Portal only)

The Government of Karnataka vide **G.O. No. UDD 429 MNY 2026, Bengaluru, Dated: 18-06-2026**, has accorded Approval in Principle and Sanctioned under GOK Grants for taking up of the work listed below.

The Executive Engineer, Vidyanarayana Division, Zone-1, BNCC, Bengaluru invites Tenders from eligible Contractors registered in BNCC or equivalent registration with CPWD KPWD / Railways / MES / National Highway or any State Government Organizations for the Construction of Works detailed below.

Sl. No.	Name of the Work
1	Package No: 01 (Package Consists of 5 Works Rs. 1350.00 Lakhs) 1) Improvements to Roads and Drains at Srinidhi Layout, Balaji Layout, Kamath Layout, Vaishnavi Layout, Ganesha Layout, D. Mandala Layout and Surrounding Area in Ward No. 08, Singapura, 2) Improvements to Roads and Drains at Singapura Paradise, Varadarajaswamy Layout, Lakkappa Layout and Surrounding Area in Ward No. 08, Singapura, 3) Improvements to Roads and Drains at M.S. Palya, Vinayakanagara, Maruthi Layout, Bharathanagara, Hosabalu Nagara and Surrounding Area in Ward No. 08, Singapura, 4) Improvements to Roads and Drains at Kuvempunagara and Ramachandrapura Surrounding Area in Ward No. 09, Kuvempunagara, 5) Improvements to Roads and Drains at Kuvempunagara 1st and 2nd Stage, Kalathur Layout, Velankini Layout and Surrounding area in Ward No. 09, Kuvempunagara. Amount Put to Tender (Rs. in Lakhs): 1088.80, EMD Amount (in Rs.): 15,00,000/- (Rs. 1.00 Lakh through KPP Portal and Rs. 14.00 Lakh in the form of B.G)
2	Package No: 02 (Package Consists of 4 Works Rs. 1000.00 Lakhs) 1) Improvements of Road and Drains in Venkataswamappa Layout, Gurudarshini Layout, Gnaneshwari Layout and Surrounding Area in Ward No. 10, Vidyanarayana, 2) Improvements of Road and Drains in BEL Layout 1st, 2nd Block, HMT Layout 5th and 6th Block, Sommantha Garden and Surrounding Area in Ward No. 10, Vidyanarayana, 3) Improvements of Road and Drains in Telecom Layout, J.V. Enclave, Uthannappa Layout, Munishamappa Layout and Surrounding Areas in Ward No. 12, Thindlu, 4) Improvements of Road and Drains in Thindlu Village, Maramma Temple Virupakshapura and Surrounding Areas in Ward No. 12, Thindlu. Amount Put to Tender (Rs. in Lakhs): 806.50, EMD Amount (in Rs.): 12,10,000/- (Rs. 1.00 Lakh through KPP Portal and Rs. 11.10 Lakh in the form of B.G)
3	Package No: 03 (Package Consists of 4 Works Rs. 1100.00 Lakhs) 1) Improvements of Road and Drains and Allied Works Doddabommasandra Village, Deshabandu Nagara, Yarrappa Garden and Kabeer Ashrama and Surrounding Area in Ward No. 11, Doddabommasandra, 2) Improvements of Road and Drains and Allied Works at Chikka Venkatappa Layout, Krishna Temple Road, Kateramma Temple Road and Surrounding Areas in Ward No. 11, Doddabommasandra, 3) Improvements of Road and Drains in Bhadrappa Layout, Muneshwara Layout, Kodigehalli Village and Surrounding Areas in Ward No. 13, Kodigehalli, 4) Improvements of Road and Drains in Tatanagar, Devanagara Hanumaiah Layout, Maruthi Nagara and Surrounding Areas in Ward No. 13, Kodigehalli. Amount Put to Tender (Rs. in Lakhs): 846.80, EMD Amount (in Rs.): 12,70,000/- (Rs. 1.00 Lakh through KPP Portal and Rs. 11.70 Lakh in the form of B.G)
4	Package No: 04 (Package Consists of 4 Works Rs. 1050.00 Lakhs) 1) Improvements of Road and Drains and Allied Works in Balaji Layout, Sonnegowda Layout, Shanubogh Layout, Sanjeevani Nagara and Surrounding Areas in Ward No. 14, Rajivgandhi Nagara, 2) Improvements of Road and Drains and Allied Works in NTI Layout, Amco Layout and Surrounding Areas in Ward No. 14, Rajivgandhi Nagara, 3) Construction of Balance Portion Retaining Wall at Singapura Gutta and Kuvempunagara in Ward No. 09, Kuvempunagara, 4) Development and Upgradation of Parks in Vidyanarayana Division. Amount Put to Tender (Rs. in Lakhs): 846.80, EMD Amount (in Rs.): 12,70,000/- (Rs. 1.00 Lakh through KPP Portal and Rs. 11.70 Lakh in the form of B.G)

Calendar of Events: 1) Tender Documents may be Downloaded from the GOK Karnataka Public Procurement Portal Website: <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> from **29-06-2026, 16.30 Hours onwards**. 2) Last Date for Receipt of Queries and Pre Bid Meeting on **01-07-2026 at 15.00 Hours**. 3) Last Date and Time for Receipt of Tenders: **08-07-2026 upto 16.00 Hours**. 4) Date and Time for Opening of Technical Bid: **09-07-2026 at 16.30 Hours**. 5) Date of Opening of Financial Bid: **Will be intimated to Bidders**. Further details can be had from the above office.

Sd/- Executive Engineer
Vidyanarayana Division, Zone-1, BNCC.

Should Indian seafarers stop serving on sanctioned ships?



Ajith Sukumaran

Retd. Additional Director General of Shipping



Biswanath Gupta

Associate Professor, Jindal Global Law School

PARLEY

While merchant ships across the world have been manned by Indian seafarers, officers, engineers and crew for years, recent conflicts have suddenly brought Indian seafarers into focus. A recent flashpoint was when the U.S. attacked three ships allegedly carrying Iranian cargo, on the grounds that they were sanctioned vessels. Three Indian seafarers were killed in those attacks. More recently, when the British detained a Russian-linked vessel that was supposedly under Western sanctions in the English Channel, the Indian captain was arrested. This raises an important question: should Indian seafarers continue serving on these so-called sanctioned ships? Ajith Sukumaran and Biswanath Gupta discuss this question in a conversation moderated by **M. Kalyanaraman**. Edited excerpts:

Could you give us some background on Indian seafarers in general?

Ajith Sukumaran: Only recently has society started realising the importance of shipping, but unfortunately from a negative point of view. Whether it was the Titanic, the Exxon Valdez incident, or more recent maritime accidents, shipping has often been in the news for the wrong reasons. But the fact is that shipping carries around 90% of global trade by volume. It is the lifeline of modern society.

The Ever Given incident in 2021 showed this clearly. A 20,000-TEU container ship blocked the Suez Canal for six days, affecting around 20% of seaborne trade. Hundreds of ships were delayed, and loss to world trade was enormous.

The Strait of Hormuz is equally important. It carries around 11-12% of global seaborne trade, but it is strategically significant because of energy transportation. Nearly 25% of fossil fuels and around 20% of LNG move through this route. For India, this is critical because more than 85% of our energy requirements are imported, and almost all of it comes via ships.

But we often talk only about ships and cargo. Ships do not move on their own. They are operated by people. Seafarers take these vessels through difficult and risky situations, and society needs to recognise their contribution. These are high-value and high-risk assets, and they need competent professionals.

Modern cargoes also involve huge risks. LNG carriers, for example, carry enormous energy potential, yet they may be operated by only around 20-21 seafarers. Indian seafarers have been among the most respected in international shipping. They have built a reputation for their discipline and technical competence. Globally,



Vessels at the Strait of Hormuz as seen from Oman on June 18. REUTERS

there are around 1.8 million seafarers. India has more than five lakh registered seafarers, of whom around 3.2 lakh are active. This means one in five seafarers in global shipping is Indian. The foreign exchange contribution from Indian seafarers is estimated at between \$6 billion and \$9 billion annually. Their importance to India is much greater than many people realise.

What is India's position on the sanctions imposed by countries such as the U.S., the U.K. and the European Union?

AS: There is a legal and a practical aspect. There are two broad categories of sanctions. One is UN sanctions, which are binding. The other is unilateral sanctions imposed by individual countries or groups such as the U.S., the U.K., the EU or the G-7. The challenge is that each country has its own list. It is not always easy to draw a line between sanctioned and non-sanctioned vessels. From the government's perspective, the issue is also practical. India has to protect its trade and its seafarers while dealing with international realities.

Should the government track these vessels and advise Indian seafarers not to join them?

AS: Whether India should impose a blanket ban is a political decision. Such a move would have consequences because India imports energy from different countries and employment is also important. The Directorate General of Shipping has issued guidelines that seafarers should be aware of the type of vessel they are joining and the risks involved. But every sanctioned vessel is not necessarily unsafe. If it is not operating in regions enforcing those sanctions, the situation changes. Therefore, it is not easy to identify every vessel and prohibit Indians from joining it.

What is the legal position on these sanctions



The Directorate General of Shipping has issued guidelines that seafarers should be aware of the type of vessel they are joining and the risks involved. But every sanctioned vessel is not necessarily unsafe

AJITH SUKUMARAN

and on the arrest of the captain in the U.K.?

Biswanath Gupta: There are two kinds of sanctions. UN Security Council sanctions passed under Chapter VII of the UN Charter are binding under international law. Unilateral sanctions are more contested. They are technically limited to the jurisdiction of the country imposing them, but powerful states often try to enforce them beyond their territory. In international law, this is highly contested – whether those sanctions are binding or non-binding. If a strong country is applying sanctions, they are binding by nature.

Regarding the Indian captain, international law raises the question of jurisdiction. India can question whether the British court has jurisdiction, especially if the incident occurred on the high seas. Another option is diplomatic protection. If an Indian citizen is affected by a violation of international law abroad, India can intervene. Regarding missile attacks on ships, the issue comes under the law of armed conflict in the United Nations Charter. Questions arise about necessity, proportionality and whether proper warnings were given. If sufficient warning was not given, India can take the issue to the international court.

International maritime law has always been important because many principles of international law developed through the law of the sea. Existing maritime frameworks can be useful in protecting seafarers.

Has India signed such maritime agreements?

BG: Yes, India is part of important international maritime frameworks. Since India has a large number of seafarers working globally, these agreements are significant. Some reports suggest that seafarers killed in conflict zones were pressured to enter dangerous areas with threats relating to wages, employment. These issues can be examined through international mechanisms.

What is the difference between dark fleet vessels and sanctioned vessels?

AS: Dark fleet vessels are identified through certain criteria. These may include fraudulent registration, false insurance documents, illegal

ship-to-ship transfers, or switching off identification systems. The case of the Indian captain arrested in the English Channel was different. The issue was related to the vessel's registry and whether it was considered stateless. The ship apparently had Cameroon registration but midway through the voyage, before entering the English Channel, the ship seems to have lost the registration. We don't know how that happened. A ship must have a proper flag state. So the legal cover was that the ship was stateless. But whether the master should be held responsible is a separate question, because a captain may not always know about administrative issues.

Given this situation, what should India do?

BG: India should focus on diplomatic engagement. International platforms such as UNCLOS [United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea] provide a space where countries can negotiate and raise concerns. The International Labour Organization is also important because seafarer welfare and rights are discussed there.

But should the government tell Indian seafarers not to join these ships?

BG: That cannot be the approach for a country like India. Much of our trade happens through the sea, and shipping is also an important source of employment. These global platforms remain important for protecting our interests.

AS: Yes, it can be done. Recruitment in India happens through agencies licensed by the Directorate General of Shipping, and any directions issued by the DG Shipping are binding on them. The government could maintain a dynamic list of sanctioned or high-risk vessels and require recruitment agencies to exercise caution while placing seafarers on them.

In many cases, vulnerable seafarers – those struggling to find employment or facing certification and documentation issues – are being targeted by agents and drawn into risky jobs. These seafarers often become innocent scapegoats in larger geopolitical conflicts.

The government has already taken an important first step by requiring seafarers to be informed. But awareness alone is not enough. The vulnerability remains, and in such circumstances, I believe the government has a responsibility to step in.



To listen to the full interview
Scan the code or go to the link
www.thehindu.com

NOTEBOOK

A surgeon's paradoxical lesson for journalists to survive the news

Unlike others, journalists have a tough time getting away from the news – but there happens to be a seemingly precarious way to do it

Vasudevan Mukunth

In an episode of the TV show *Elementary*, a surgeon prepares to perform a surgery. After he dons his gloves and mask, with his students watching from the back, he plays some funny music from speakers. The students are pleasantly surprised. The surgeon turns around and tells them that they will need to learn to take performing surgeries easy. That they should not let 'it' get to them. What he means is that if a surgeon puts herself under pressure because a life is at stake, she could make more mistakes and further endanger that life.

The protagonist in the Tamil film *Doctor* stands for a similar idea, and it taught me something about remaining a journalist. Journalism done properly can exact a particular psychological toll. Just the developments pouring in from different parts of the world add to the ordinary unhappiness of the human condition. Investigative journalism, news analyses, and perceptive and knowledgeable commentary can exacerbate adverse thoughts, and make one feel helpless and one's work seem too small, even negligible, in the face of the world's profound challenges.

Some journalists who are on the ground reporting on trauma and grief often have it worse. We sometimes talk to our colleagues, friends, and family members about feeling despondent due to being journalists specifically.

Social media platforms' preference for noise, tolerance for bots, and embrace of artificial intelligence has only made matters worse.

Since graduating from journalism school and starting work, most of my batchmates have left the profession. They have done so for various reasons but one common refrain has been "the stress is not worth it". It does not mean that those who have stayed back have elected to live with stress. They have probably found a way to manage it, especially the specific variety that comes with being a journalist.

For instance, like the surgeon in *Elementary* who treats each surgery as just another task he has been trained to do, I treat many news developments as just more pieces of information I have learnt to respond to. Earthquake in Venezuela? Let us write an explainer. Climate talks failed? Think about who can write a news-analysis. Government approves drug without proper testing? Ask a medical researcher if she can write a commentary piece. Then move on.

In these instances, I have learnt to not take the information to heart. I do not think about what it means for the world, for society or for my beliefs. It is neither cause for despair nor source of hope. And it is only possible because there are others who care more so I do not have to (division of labour), freeing me up to efficiently collect, clean up, organise, and communicate knowledge. Sometimes, the problem is really that if you care too much, it could get in the way of you doing your job.

This psychological device also carries risks that we need to constantly beware and minimise.

One is that of reducing human tragedies to items on a checklist. Another is to not lose sight of the empathy required to narrate or edit a story with the requisite gravitas.

If I stop sensing the weight of the news, I could stop sensing the humanity of the people within. I also need to militate against the division of labour leading to a hollowed-out version of journalism that informs the head but ignores the heart. There is no free lunch.

But I have personally found this to be more maintainable than always feeling the weight in full. There are also those few topics where I really do care, perhaps even too much, like democratising scientific publishing.

The next time you meet a journalist, ask them how they are managing their stress. It is probably why they are still at it.

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PICTURE OF THE WEEK

A swirling vortex in the wild



Spinning top: A rare tornado-like funnel cloud formed amid a sudden downpour near Pudukottai and Vaagaikulam in Thoothukudi district, Tamil Nadu on June 21. The tornado ripped off the roof of a few structures in the mini theme park near the Vaagaikulam toll plaza. However, no fatalities were reported. PTI

FROM THE ARCHIVES

FIFTY YEARS AGO JUNE 26, 1976

All crew of sunken ship rescued

Visakhapatnam, June 25: All the 28 crew members of the ill-faten Greek ship, "Elasta Piracus" that sank near the Andamans on June 20 were rescued to-day by the Eastern Naval Command after an intensive search.

They were noticed drifting towards the west coast of the Middle Andamans, 90 km north of Port Blair, by an Indian Air Force plane and the Shipping Corporation of India vessel, "Viswa Anand". Life boats were lowered by

The Hindu

the ship and the crew members rescued around noon.

A spokesman of the Eastern Naval Command here said the operations were carried out by the Naval-officer of Andaman Nicobar, under guidance from Vice Admiral Swaraj Parakash, Flag Officer Commanding in Chief, Eastern Naval Command.

The Greek ship, carrying 10,000 tonnes of milled scrap had left Paradeep Port on June 17. Water entered the ship on the night of June 19. An SOS was sent to the Vizag base on June 20 when search operations began by the Naval ships, IAF and merchant ships.

Samachar reports: "Viswa Anand" picked up the survivors from Rocky Island and proceeded to Port Blair.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO JUNE 26, 1926

Cow's brain from cow's milk

The sittings of the International Vegetarian Union Congress were resumed at the Central Hall, Westminster.

Dr. Stavros Damoglod (Greece), dealing with the question, "What is true vegetarianism," said that during the twelve years he had practised in London he had advised abstinence from dairy produce to hundreds of patients. He would say, without any hesitation or fear of contradiction, that anyone who indulged in large quantities of cow's milk developed the brains and mentality of a cow, and was only a cow in human form.

From Page One

188 dead, 1,500 hurt in Venezuela earthquakes

Officials were trying to make the most of the day-light hours to rescue people believed to be trapped under the rubble, the Interim President said.

“Deeply saddened by the devastation caused by the severe earthquakes in Venezuela,” Prime Minister Narendra Modi said in a statement. “We pray for the speedy recovery of those injured and stand in solidarity with all those affected... India stands ready to extend all possible assistance,” he said.

The U.S. “stands ready, willing, and able to help,” President Donald Trump said in a social media post.

“We have a whole-of-government response. It will be big, it will be fast, and it will be effective,” U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio told reporters during a visit to Bahrain, saying his country’s military would play a “big logistical role”. Washington is closely involved in oil-rich Venezuela after U.S. forces captured President Nicolas Maduro in January.

The strongest earthquake to hit Venezuela in 126 years will require “massive collective efforts”, the United Nations’ aid chief Tom Fletcher said in a statement. He said the UN was “fully mobilised” to send aid.

(With inputs from AP and Reuters)

Three States close ranks on Tungabhadra basin

The Chief Ministers said the three States have arrived at a historic consensus to safeguard the interests of farmers in the Tungabhadra basin.

Ahead of the inauguration, the three Chief Ministers held a nearly hour-long meeting with Union Jal Shakti Minister C.R. Patil to discuss key irrigation issues concerning the three States.

Desilting of the Tungabhadra reservoir, where an estimated 33 tmcft of silt has accumulated over the years significantly affecting its storage capacity, was discussed.

Mr. Patil said the Union government will first dredge the Tungabhadra dam as part of its larger plan to desilt major reservoirs.

He said the Chief Ministers had expressed their commitment to extend full cooperation in the exercise.

Dredging work

Pointing out that silt accumulation had reduced the storage capacity of many dams, including the Tungabhadra, Mr. Patil said that, as per the proposed programme, the Centre will provide the technical support, and the dredging would be completed at the earliest possible time with the involvement of the three States.

Calling the replacement of all the 33 spillway gates of the Tungabhadra dam “historic”, Mr. Shivakumar said it was done in the larger interest of farmers and the long-term safety of the reservoir.

Govt. restores LPG supply to pre-war level

“In a major relief to industrial and commercial LPG consumers, the government has removed all sectoral restrictions on the supply of non-domestic packed LPG and restored supplies to the levels prevailing prior to the West Asia crisis,” the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas stated.

At the peak of the crisis in early March, the government had issued orders to temporarily restrict the supply of commercial LPG. This was gradually eased to provide 70% of the pre-crisis level requirements across multiple tranches – including the conditional 10% allocation to States and Union Territories for facilitating expedited transition to piped natural gas (PNG).

Twenty-two States had received the additional commercial LPG allocation.The Ministry stated that it continued to retain its resolve to expand PNG coverage. At the peak of the crisis, the government had called for a transition to PNG in a bid to ease pressure on LPG.

“Commercial and bulk consumers who have already shifted to PNG will continue to remain on PNG,” the statement said. “Other eligible LPG consumers having access to the PNG network, or those in the process of shifting to PNG, will be progressively transitioned to PNG in coordination with City Gas Distribution (CGD) entities.”

CBI conducts searches over digital arrests

“Leveraging advanced forensic tools and technical expertise, the CBI identified critical elements of the criminal infrastructure operating both within India and abroad. Investigation has revealed that the perpetrators uploaded forged documents, including fake orders resembling those issued by courts and various law enforcement agencies, to lend credibility to their fraudulent activities,” the central agency said.

During the searches, the CBI seized several incriminating documents, digital devices, phones and records relating to bank transactions. It found evidence indicating that several foreign nationals too may have been cheated by the same network. The law enforcement agencies of the jurisdictions concerned are being alerted through appropriate channels, the agency said.

In blockaded part of Manipur, an LPG cylinder now sells for ₹5,000

40 people killed in the State since President’s Rule was revoked in February; Deputy CM blocked from travel to Imphal; rice and petrol prices more than double in Kangpokpi district; efforts are on to ensure movement of convoys carrying essentials

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

Prices of essentials such as rice, petrol, and cooking gas have spiralled in Kangpokpi district of Manipur over the last month, due to a severe economic blockade being imposed since May 13, when three Thadou pastors were killed in the Kuki-dominated district.

The blockade is so severe that Deputy Chief Minister Nemcha Kipgen, who represents Kangpokpi in the Manipur Assembly, is yet to travel to the State capital, Imphal, since the elected government was restored after President’s Rule was revoked. Four months after she took oath, she still virtually attends the meetings called by Chief Minister Y. Khemchand Singh in Imphal.

At least 40 people have been killed in Manipur since February 4, when President’s Rule was revoked, in a fresh wave of ethnic conflict that has now spread to the Naga and Kuki communities. The north-



In limbo: Truckers have frequently demanded better security for convoys carrying essential supplies in Manipur. FILE PHOTO

eastern State is inhabited by three major communities: the Meitei who dominate the Imphal valley and the tribal Kuki-Zo and Naga people who largely live in the surrounding hills. So far, around 300 people have been killed since ethnic violence, initially between Meiteis and Kukis, erupted in the State on May 3, 2023.

Due to Kangpokpi’s location – surrounded by the Naga-dominated Senapati district in the north and the Meitei-dominated valley districts in the south –

transportation of essential items has been severely affected, with Naga village volunteers imposing a blockade on goods entering from outside the State.

Despite initiatives taken by the State government, daily items are scarcely available, according to Haokholet Kipgen, the MLA from Saitu constituency in Kangpokpi. There is no supply of LPG cylinders and those already in the district are being sold for ₹5,000 in the black market. A 50-kg bag of rice, which cost ₹1,400 to ₹1,700 before

the blockade is now being sold at ₹4,000, the MLA told *The Hindu*.

Thangminlen Kipgen, president of Sadar Hills (Kangpokpi), a civil society group, said there has been a noticeable difference in administration since the elected government was restored, but the district’s access to National Highway-2, which connects it to Dimapur in Nagaland has been blocked since May 13. About 70% of daily supplies are brought to Kangpokpi through the arterial road, he said.

Local inflation

“It is always the poor who are affected by such incidents. Because of shortage of cooking gas, people switched to induction tops, which is leading to frequent power cuts of seven to eight hours. The cost of transportation has gone up. A litre of petrol costs ₹250 to ₹280. There is no way to control this local inflation. It has an effect on all commodities,” Mr. Kipgen said.

A senior security force

official confirmed that several groups have been placing illegal blockades along NH-2, and added that efforts are on to ensure the movement of convoys carrying essential supplies. Over the past week, around 30 bunkers set up by village volunteers have been dismantled, the official said.

After the bodies of six missing Naga men, including two pastors, were recovered on June 10 from Kangpokpi, the blockades have intensified. The six men and their family members were abducted on May 13 following the killing of three Thadou church leaders in an ambush the same day in Kangpokpi.

At least 44 civilians were reportedly taken hostage by Kuki and Naga groups in Kangpokpi and Senapati districts. While several of those abducted were released earlier, 14 members of the Kuki community who remained in captivity were released on June 9, a day before the bodies of the Naga hostages were recovered.

Kuki-Zo body admits six Nagas were killed by Kukis

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

The Kuki-Zo Council (KZC), the apex body of the Kuki-Zo tribes in Manipur, on Thursday admitted that members of their community executed six Liangmai Naga villagers who were abducted after three Thadou church leaders were killed in an ambush more than a month ago.

Owning up to the “great mistake” in a video while addressing media persons, KZC chairman Henlianthang Thanglet said the six Naga men were killed during an outburst of emotion. “I really criticise it,” he said in the company of KZC spokesperson Ginza Vualzong.

This was the first known public expression of regret by any Kuki individual or civil society organisation over the killing of the six Naga civilians. Their whereabouts were not known until security forces recovered their decomposed and dismembered bodies on June 11.

On June 8, the National Investigation Agency took over the probe into the killing of the three Thadou church leaders.

Toll in Kolkata warehouse collapse rises to 11; Bengal CM orders audit of building plans



Mahesh Dixit

Mahesh Dixit appointed Intelligence Bureau chief

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

Mahesh Dixit, a 1993 batch Indian Police Service (IPS) officer of the Andhra Pradesh cadre has been appointed as Director, Intelligence Bureau (DIB), a government order said.

He succeeds Tapan Kumar Deka, who held the post since 2022. His tenure ends on June 30.

Mr. Dixit, a medical doctor by education, has led the Jammu and Kashmir (J&K) desk and has also served in Nagaland and Bihar.

He was Deputy Director of IB in J&K from 2009-12 and from 2012-15, he was posted in Nagaland.

He took charge of the Subsidiary Intelligence Bureau (SIB) of J&K in 2020 and served there till 2024, overseeing the security preparedness and intelligence-based operations post revocation of Article 370 in the erstwhile State.

He is among the Home Ministry officials who are engaged in talks with civil society leaders of Ladakh.

The Appointments Committee of the Cabinet (ACC) on Thursday approved the appointment of Mr. Dixit, Special Director, IB as Director, Intelligence Bureau for a tenure of two years from the date of assumption of the charge of the post or until further orders, whichever is earlier, the order said.

Due to retire in August 2027, he has been granted extension in service under the provisions of FR 56(d) and Rule 16 (IA) of All India Services (Death cum Retirement Benefits) Rules, 1958, the order said.

Shiv Sahay Singh
Senjuti Sengupta
KOLKATA

The death toll in the Kolkata warehouse collapse increased to 11 on Thursday. Nineteen of the injured are undergoing treatment in the State-run SSKM Hospital. Three 17-year-old workers are among the 11 deceased from West Bengal and Bihar.

Chief Minister Suvenud Adhikari announced a compensation of ₹10 lakh to the next of kin of the deceased and ₹1 lakh to the injured. Prime Minister Narendra Modi also announced a compensation of ₹2 lakh to the kin of those who lost their lives and ₹50,000 to the injured.

Speaking in the Legislative Assembly, Mr. Adhikari said a first information report (FIR) had been registered and five persons had



NDRF personnel on Thursday check the site where a warehouse under construction collapsed in the Taratala area of Kolkata. ANI

been arrested. He claimed the building design was faulty.

The Chief Minister announced suspension of all ongoing construction projects in the Kolkata Municipal Corporation area and adjoining areas of Rajarhat, Sonarpur, Baruipur and Maheshtala, adding that building plans in these areas would undergo a comprehensive audit.

Mr. Adhikari announced that a high-level committee had been constituted for the purpose, headed by Rajesh Pandey, IAS, which will submit a report in seven days. Mr. Adhikari blamed the former Trinamool Congress regime for the irregularities and corruption that resulted in the accident.

“About 12.05 p.m., one under-construction ware-

house on Transport Depot Road in Taratala collapsed and a few labourers got stuck under the debris. Five of them were declared brought dead to the hospital. The rescue operation was conducted by the Kolkata Police DMG, KMC personnel, fire services personnel, civil defence and NDRF. The operation is still continuing,” said Additional Commissioner of Police (Crime), Kunal Agrawal.

The FIR has been lodged under Sections 105/110/3(5) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, which amount to culpable homicide not amounting to murder, attempt to commit culpable homicide and joint criminal liability.

The FIR named six persons of whom structural engineer Kamal Samanta, Syed MD Gulzar Hussain, Sambhunath Behera, Dibakar Bhandari and Abdul Hamid were arrested.

The accident occurred on Wednesday when the multi-storey warehouse being constructed by a private operator on land leased out by the Syama Prasad Mookerjee Port Authority (SMPA) came crashing down.

One rescued alive

Rescue operations continued on Thursday and at least one person was rescued alive. The heavy rain on Thursday afternoon hampered the rescue operations.

According to those present at the site, 50 to 60 people were at work when the accident took place. Local people said they heard several workers buried under the debris crying out for help. Attempts were made to drill a hole through the debris and reach out to the trapped workers, and oxygen and food were made available.

Muslim bodies denounce demolitions of religious structures, seek legal relief

Ziya Us Salam
NEW DELHI

Several prominent Muslim bodies have united to condemn the spate of demolitions of mosques, madrasas and dargahs across Rajasthan, Maharashtra, Uttarakhand, and Uttar Pradesh. They have also decided to seek legal relief over these actions.

Arshad Madani, president, Jamiat Ulama-i-Hind said: “An undeclared emergency is effectively in force in the country today. Demolishing people’s homes and places of worship while disregarding legal procedures and court rulings is contrary to the fundamental principles of the Constitution. If governments begin dispensing justice through bulldozers instead of courts, what is the meaning of the rule of

law and citizens’ rights? The government cannot act as a judge; determining legality and illegality is the responsibility of the judiciary alone.”

His viewpoint was supported by the spokesman of Jamaat-e-Islami Hind who expressed “grave concern over demolition drives affecting religious structures, residential buildings and vulnerable communities across several States” and promised legal help for those fighting demolitions carried out without following the due process of law.

“Jamaat-e-Islami Hind will continue to support the victims of these demolitions and advocate for their rights at all levels,” the spokesman said.

In a separate conference, the All India Muslim Personal Law Board

(AIMPLB) bemoaned the marginalisation of minorities as manifest in the demolition of mosques in Rajasthan’s Jaisalmer, Barmer and Bikaner. The Board promised to launch a “nationwide movement in collaboration with justice-loving people from across communities” against social and political marginalisation of Muslims. Zafarul Islam Khan, former chairman, Delhi Minorities Commission, expressed similar concern at the spate of demolitions of Muslim places of worship even as he called upon the youth to maintain calm.

The Muslim bodies decided to file petitions in the high courts in Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh to restore the mosques demolished as well as for those mosques that have been served eviction notice.

Passport application fee to go up from July 1

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The application fee for an ordinary fresh passport containing 36 pages has been hiked from ₹1,500 to ₹2,500, as the Union government revised the passport fee structure through an amendment to the Passports Rules, 1980.

The new rules will come into effect from July 1.

According to a notification dated June 20, and published by the Ministry of

External Affairs on Thursday, the reissue of a 36-page passport will also cost ₹2,500. A tatkal application for a fresh or reissued passport will cost ₹5,000 as opposed to the current ₹3,500 rate.

Similarly, the application fee for an ordinary fresh passport or reissue of a passport containing 60 pages has been hiked from ₹2,000 to ₹3,500. The tatkal fee for 60-page passports will be ₹6,000 as against the current ₹4,000.

APPEAL
Master Sayyed Affan Mubin, Christian Medical College Hospital No.A174138, 5 years has been Diagnosed to have Thalassemia Major. This is a type of Life-Threatening Blood Disorder. The best option for him would be to undergo Allogeneic Peripheral Blood Stem Cell Transplant (PBSCT). The estimated cost of PBSCT at this hospital is approximately Rs.16, 00,000/-.

Please send donation however small by Cheque/D.D/M.O Fav. **Save Poor Lives A/c Sayyed Affan Mubin, Our A/c Details:** S/B A/c No. 20000913487, S.B.I. R.A.Puram, IFSC CODE:SBIN001855. Please Donate by G-pay No.9884607377, UPI Id: savepoorlives@oksb. Donations are exempted under 80G of I.T.ACT.

SAVE POOR LIVES, Flat No. A1, Ceebros Garden, Door No.14/76, Kamarajar Salai, Raja Annamalaiapuram, Chennai-600028. Ph. No. 044 42044165 / 9884607377. Email: savepoorlives@gmail.com. Our website: www.savepoorlives.com

FIR filed against 8 persons over ‘embezzlement’ at Ram Temple

It mentions charges of fraud, criminal conspiracy, and breach of trust; the SIT had submitted its preliminary report two days ago; Opposition parties say powerful people who oversaw the whole process of donation collection are being protected

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

The Uttar Pradesh Police on Thursday registered a first information report against eight persons over allegations of embezzlement of donations at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya.

The FIR was registered based on a complaint by Krishna Mohan, a member of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Trust. It mentions eight individuals – Ramashankar Yadav, alias Tinnu; Manish Yadav; Luvkush Mishra; Karunesh Pandey; Rama Shankar Mishra; Subhash Srivastava; Anukalp Mishra; and Avinash Shukla – and other unidentified accused. It mentions charges of embezzlement, fraud, criminal conspiracy, and breach of trust under various Section of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.



Ongoing row: The FIR was filed based on a complaint by Krishna Mohan, a member of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Trust. FILE PHOTO

tiya Nyaya Sanhita.

The FIR comes two days after a Special Investigation Team submitted a preliminary report of its findings to the State government on Tuesday.

Reacting to the development, Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav described it as a glimpse of

injustice. He added that powerful culprits would be protected. “This will be a glimpse of injustice under BJP rule. The small will be hanged, the branches will be forgiven. The public is saying that first, under the pretext of SIT, all the evidence would have been cleared and it would have

been decided which big fishes are to be saved and who is to be trapped, only after that the FIR is being lodged. It seems the report would have been prepared and given to the SIT first and the investigation would have been conducted accordingly, meaning the conclusion would have been drawn first,” he wrote on social media platform X.

Uttar Pradesh Congress unit president Ajay Rai alleged that the FIR had been filed just to silence the anger of common devotees of Lord Ram. He added that the State government was trying to save big people like Champat Rai.

“Orders have been issued to register an FIR in the theft at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya. But, in the FIR, driver and small culprits are named. The government is trying to protect

real culprits like Champat Rai Bansal and other Trust members who oversaw the whole process of donation collection. Without their permission and active involvement such a massive theft cannot occur, amid so much security and the presence of so many police,” said Mr. Rai.

Tough action sought

Vishwa Hindu Parishad international president AloK Kumar on Wednesday called for a comprehensive investigation and an FIR into allegations of irregularities in donations collected for the Ram Janmabhoomi temple, saying those found guilty should face the strictest legal action.

Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on June 19 said “truth will prevail” after the SIT completed its probe.

Opposition seeks rollback of new FCRA Rules, flags impact on civil society

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Congress general secretary (organisation) K.C. Venugopal and Communist Party of India (Marxist) Rajya Sabha leader John Brittas have written to Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah, respectively, seeking the withdrawal of the recently notified Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Rules, 2026, arguing that the changes would adversely affect the functioning of civil society organisations.

The new rules, notified on June 22, require non-governmental organisations (NGOs) to register under one of five categories – social, economic, educational, cultural, and religious – with separate activity lists prescribed for each. Organisations must also disclose details of their activities, geographical scope,



K.C. Venugopal

websites, social media accounts and publications, and pay separate fees for each category and State or Union Territory in which they operate.

In his letter to Mr. Modi, Mr. Venugopal said the amendments amounted to an attempt to curb the independence of NGOs. “These rules are an overt and systemic assault on India’s civil society, designed not to regulate, but to strangle the non-governmental organisations (NGOs) that form the backbone

of our grassroots developmental and social welfare frameworks,” he wrote. He argued that forcing NGOs to choose from a “rigid, government-mandated list” of activities and restricting their operational geography would undermine their ability to respond to emergencies.

Constitutional concerns

In his letter to Mr. Shah, Mr. Brittas raised constitutional concerns, arguing that the amendments go beyond financial regulation and alter the nature of oversight over voluntary organisations. “Collectively, these changes signify a decisive shift from regulating foreign contribution to regulating voluntary organisations themselves,” he wrote. He said the rules introduced vague and undefined terms such as “proselytisation,” which could lead to arbitrary interpretation.

Punjab CM says ‘mask’ used to create fake video

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH

Amid the ongoing controversy over an objectionable video, Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Thursday said a conspiracy had been hatched to malign his image on religious grounds, even as the Opposition parties accused the Chief Minister of misleading the people of Punjab with diversionary statements.

Mr. Mann alleged that a Canada-based person, whom he identified as Jagman Samra, had used a mask resembling his face to create the video. “The fake video was filmed in a



Bhagwant Mann

hotel in Canada, whereas I have not visited the country since 2016. The mask was clearly visible in the video and my neck surgery scar was missing. The makers of the fake video have been identified and will be

exposed after verification,” he said at a press conference here. He said the matter would be placed before the Akal Takht, the highest Sikh temporal seat, along with the evidence.

On June 15, the Sikh clergy at Akal Takht had declared Mr. Mann *Guru Dohi* (a betrayer of the Guru) and *Khalsa Panth Virodhi* (opponent of the Sikh community).

‘For political benefit’

“For the past several days, a fake and fabricated video of mine has been circulated repeatedly. Religious directives were also issued only to derive political benefit,” Mr. Mann said.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Recurring examination irregularities are evidence of a massive institutional failure, senior Congress leader and president of the party’s Assam unit Gaurav Gogoi said on Thursday, announcing the launch of “*Chhatron Ki Goonj*”, a 40-day nationwide campaign to highlight issues affecting students.

Mr. Gogoi said repeated instances of paper leaks and disruptions had created a perception among students that the problem was “systemic” rather than the fault of a few individuals. “The trust of India’s stu-



Gaurav Gogoi

dents has been broken. Who will take responsibility for so many broken dreams?” he said. The government has to be held accountable for the injustice done to students and the parents who are shouldering the financial burden, he added.

As part of the campaign,

the Congress plans to engage with students and collect feedback on issues ranging from examination paper leaks and recruitment delays to broader concerns in the education sector.

According to NSUI leaders, the campaign was launched simultaneously at 28 locations across the country. It will involve outreach in educational institutions, town hall meetings, corner meetings, public dialogues and pamphlet distribution. Students affected by examinations such as NEET, JEE and SSC, as well as those facing issues related to school education, will be

contacted during the campaign, they said. The organisation has also introduced a registration mechanism through a QR code and a missed-call facility to enable students to share grievances.

Referring to recurring controversies surrounding examinations, Mr. Gogoi said many students believed the problems reflected deeper institutional shortcomings. “When it gets repeated every year, there is this belief among the student community that this cannot be the failure of one individual. This is the failure of an entire system,” he said.

He said Congress leader

Rahul Gandhi had also raised the issue during a recent interaction in Rajasthan’s Kota, describing it as a wider crisis affecting the education system. “As a result, the youth of the country are not being able to move forward. If the youth cannot move forward, then the country will not be able to move forward either,” Mr. Gogoi said.

Student leaders said the first phase of the campaign would continue till August 9. If their demands were not addressed, they would mobilise students from across the country for a “Delhi Chalo” programme and a protest in the national capital.

Sujata Rout, ex- IAS officer and wife of V.K. Pandian, joins BJD

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

Sujata Rout Karthikeyan, a former IAS officer and wife of V.K. Pandian, a close aide of Biju Janata Dal (BJD) supremo Naveen Patnaik, joined the party on Thursday.

The announcement came alongside a strong assertion from Mr. Patnaik, who sought to quell speculation over leadership of the party, stating that he would continue to lead the BJD in the next elections. The statement was intended to put the succession debate to rest.

Ms. Rout joined the BJD in the presence of Mr. Patnaik at Sankha Bhavan, the party’s State headquarters here. The 2000-batch Odisha-cadre IAS officer had taken voluntary retirement in 2025. Her entry into politics comes in the aftermath of the BJD’s defeat in the 2024 elections.

“I would like to welcome Ms. Sujata Rout to BJD. She will be joining as a simple member of the party,” Mr. Patnaik said.

The BJD leadership believes that Ms. Rout could help revive the party’s crucial women voter base through her extensive grass roots connections.

Envoy takes charge in Dhaka; travel visas to resume

Press Trust of India
DHAKA/NEW DELHI

India’s new High Commissioner to Dhaka, Dinesh Trivedi, on Thursday announced the resumption of travel visas for Bangladesh nationals as he assumed office.

Earlier, the 76-year-old Bharatiya Janata Party leader presented his credentials to President Mohammed Shahabuddin, marking the start of his diplomatic assignment.

He was named as the envoy to Bangladesh on April 27, becoming the first politician to serve in this position.

The government has granted Mr. Trivedi the status equivalent to a Union Cabinet Minister, according to a government order.

An order issued on Wednesday (June 24) by the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) said Mr. Trivedi “has been assigned the equivalent status of Union Cabinet Minister in the Table of Precedence (ToP) as a measure personal to him, without amending the Table of Precedence”.

Halted two years ago

The travel visas were halted nearly two years ago amid an escalated security situation and deteriorating



Dinesh Trivedi

ties with New Delhi during the Muhammad Yunus-led interim regime.

“I am very happy to be able to announce the launch of general travel visas again. Visa applications can be submitted starting June 28,” he said. Mr. Trivedi said visas would be issued from all five centres – Dhaka, Rajshahi, Chattogram, Sylhet, and Khulna – and the process would be expanded further in the future.

The envoy said urgent medical visas would continue to be provided for humanitarian reasons. Travel visas for Bangladeshi nationals typically permit access to India for tourism, medical treatments, government and business assignments.

He arrived in Bangladesh through its western Benapole-Petrapole land border on June 12.

GREATER VISAKHAPATNAM MUNICIPAL CORPORATION
RFP Tender Notice No. 12/2026-27/SE/Works - V & PL&C/EE (Anakapalli, Pendurthi)/DB/GVMC/Dt:25-06-2026
Number of work - 01, Value of work: RFP Tender
Tender Opening Dt. 27.06.2026 @ 05.00 PM, Closing Date,13-07-2026 @ 4.00 PM
Note: Further details at <https://tender.apeprocurement.gov.in>
O/o the SE(PL&C) Cell No.9951532876 For Commissioner

GOVERNMENT OF TELANGANA
PUBLIC HEALTH AND MUNICIPAL ENGINEERING DEPARTMENT
NITs: 01/TUFDIC/UNIT-II/SBM 2.0/27 ULBs/2026-27 Dt: 25.06.2026
Name of the work: Sewerage Projects in 27 ULBs under SBM 2.0 under jurisdiction of Nalgonda and Khannam PH Divisions (Package-II) under LS contract system with Hybrid Annuity Model, Total Cost: Rs. 880.02 Crores; Bid Download Start Date: 01.07.2026 @ 11.00 AM; Pre-Bid Meeting Date: 06.07.2026 @ 11.00 AM @ Conference Hall, 7th floor, O/o ENC (PH), Hyderabad; Bid Submission Start Date: 09.07.2026 @ 11.00 AM; Bid Submission Closing Date: 27.07.2026 @ 04.30 PM. For details visit <https://tender.telangana.gov.in>. Contact No:- 8978261291, 9160042233.
Sd/- Superintending Engineer (PH),
DIPR R.O.No.4939-PP/CL/ADVT/2026-27 Dt. 25.06.2026 TUFDIC, UNIT-II, NALGONDA.

Rajasthan State Road Development And Construction Corporation Ltd., JAIPUR			
No.: NIT/2026-27/379-88		अल्पकालीन ई-निविदा सूचना संख्यां 197/2026-27 Date: 24/06/2026	
निविदा/बिडिंग कार्य के लिए केन्द्र / राज्य सरकार के अधीनस्थित विभागों एवं उनके अधिकृत संगठनों में पंजीकृत एवं अनुमति संवेदकों से निर्धारित प्रारंभ में ई-प्रोक्चरमेंट प्रक्रिया हेतु अधिलेखन/निविदाएं आमंत्रित की जाती है।			
कार्य का विवरण		कार्य की कुल अनुमानित लागत (₹)	
Various Development/Rehabilitation works in 13 Nos. Temple at Sanganer, Jaipur under Unit-IV, Jaipur, RSRC Ltd., Jaipur. UBN: RRC2627WS0800311		385.00 Lakh	
निविदा से सम्बंधित प्रारंभ में निविदा शुल्क, धरोहर राशि, डाउनलोड करने व खोलने की तारीख सहित सम्पूर्ण विवरण एवं संशोधन वेबसाइट: http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in , http://sppp.rajasthan.nic.in तथा http://pwr.rajasthan.gov.in/rsrc पर देखा जा सकता है। इच्छुक संवेदकों को अपने डिजिटल हस्ताक्षर के माध्यम से वेबसाइट http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in पर रजिस्टर्ड करवाना आवश्यक है।			
		प्रत्यक्ष	

GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA
HIGHER EDUCATION DEPARTMENT
Lokseva Bhawan, Sachivalaya Marg, Bhubaneswar-751001
PT4-HE4T-MISC-0016-2023-34572/HE, Bhubaneswar, Dated: 25.06.2026
Corrigendum
DEVELOPMENT OF 83 DIGITAL APPLICATION MODULES UNDER THE COMPREHENSIVE DIGITAL GOVERNANCE PLATFORM ALONG WITH RESOURCE DEPLOYMENT COMPONENT AND TO INTEGRATE IT WITH EXISTING ERP OF HIGHER EDUCATION DEPARTMENT.

Sl. No.	Reference	Description	Date
1.	Bid Submission Dateline	Last Date & Time for Submission of Proposal	The last date & time for submission of RFP proposals is hereby extended. The revised dateline for submission of Bids: 03.07.2026, 05:00 PM for wider participation of PSUs.

Sd/- Deputy Secretary to Government

11001/158/2627

OIPR-11001/11001/1/26-27/0019

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Date of Admission Test : 19.07.2026
Please Contact Between 10:00 am to 05:00 pm
SHOUKAT ALI SECRETARY
UNMESH MISHRA DIRECTOR

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF GENERAL MANAGER (P&C), IDCO, IDCO TOWER, BHUBANESWAR.
TCN No.18961 dt.24.06.2026
NOTICE INVITING TENDER UNDER NATIONAL COMPETITIVE BIDDING THROUGH e-Procurement
1. Name of the Work: Engagement of Consultant for preparation of Detailed Project Reports (DPRs) for Industrial Parks under Bharat Audyogik Vikas Yojna (BHAVYA).
2. Availability of tender online for Bidding:
I. Start Date: 18:00 Hours of dt.25.06.2026.
II. End date: 17:00 Hours of dt.03.07.2026.
III. Opening date: 17:30 Hours of dt.03.07.2026.
Tender details can be seen from the e-procurement portal www.tendersorissa.gov.in.
Corrigendum or Addendum if any will not be published in newspapers and can be seen in e-procurement portal as well as in IDCO website.
Sd/- Chief General Manager (P&C), IDCO, Bhubaneswar
OIPR-4001/4075/1/26-27/0062

Government of Odisha
Housing & Urban Development Department
Odisha Urban Housing Mission (OUHM)
(WATCO Building, 3rd Floor, Keshari Nagar, Bhubaneswar-751001)
E-mail- ouhmodisha@gmail.com, Phone- 0674-2534432, Website: www.urban.odisha.gov.in

File No. HUD-HU-ADM-0006-2017 ADVERTISEMENT
No: 759 Date: 25.06.2026
Applications are invited for appointment to the post of Member (One) in the Odisha Real Estate Regulatory Authority (ORERA) to be appointed in accordance with the provisions of Sections 20,21,22,23 & 24 of the Real Estate (Regulation and Development) Act, 2016 and Rule 18 & 19 of the Odisha Real Estate (Regulation & Development) Rules, 2017.
The Member of the Odisha Real Estate Regulatory Authority (ORERA) shall hold office for a term not exceeding 5 (five) years from the date on which he/she enters upon his/her office, or until he/she attains the age of 65 (Sixty-Five) years, whichever is earlier and shall not be eligible for reappointment. The Member of the ORERA shall perform such duties and functions and exercise such powers as provided under the Real Estate (Regulation and Development) Act, 2016, and the Odisha Real Estate (Regulation and Development) Rules, 2017, made thereunder. The Head Office of the Authority will be at Bhubaneswar.
For complete information on qualification, eligibility criteria, application form and other details, the interested persons may visit and download the same from the Department's website <https://www.urban.odisha.gov.in> or <https://rera.odisha.gov.in>. The last date for receipt of applications complete in all respects is by 03.00 PM of Dt.15.07.2026.
Sd/- (Usha Padhee, IAS), Additional Chief Secretary
OIPR-13001/13284/1/26-27/0001

13001/986/2627

A CH-CE

INBRIEF



S&P upgrades Adani Ports to BBB; cites strong cash flows

S&P Global Ratings on Thursday upgraded Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone (APSEZ) to investment-grade BBB from BBB-, citing robust cash generation and strengthening balance sheet while maintaining healthy leverage. S&P assigned stable outlook on APSEZ, reflecting expectation that the company will sustain strong operating performance over the next 12-24 months and keep net debt-to-EBITDA ratio at around 2.6 times despite elevated capital spending. PTI

ONGC appoints BP as TSP for Western Offshore Basin

Further expanding on their previous technical services collaboration for Mumbai High Field, State-owned Oil and Natural Gas Corporation (ONGC) has appointed British oil major BP as its technical services provider (TSP) for the overall Western Offshore Basin. “The collaboration will seek to moderate natural production decline, improve hydrocarbon recovery and operational efficiency, and support sustained production growth,” ONGC said in a statement.

‘Big 6 Indian auditors audited 66% of Nifty 500 firms in ’25-26

The six largest audit firms in India by number of clients have audited 66% of Nifty 500 companies as of 2025-26, according to PRIME Database data. EY, KPMG, Deloitte, GT Group, BDO Group and PWC Group, including their associates, handled audit consulting of 779 clients in 2025-26, up from 722 the previous year. BDO Group increased client count the most by 17 companies in the past. Deloitte was the only group among the Big 6 that lost six clients in a year, going by the data.

LIC chief financial officer Agrawal quits

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

The Life Insurance Corporation of India’s chief financial officer (CFO) Sunil Agrawal has resigned to pursue better prospects. “His resignation will be effective from the close of business hours of July 14 when he would cease to be CFO and key managerial personnel of the Corporation,” LIC said. Mr. Agrawal joined as CFO in March 2022 ahead of LIC’s initial public offering. Earlier, he was with Reliance Nippon Life Insurance for more than 12 years and ICICI Prudential Life for over five years.

Adani unveils six airport-city projects worth ₹20,000 cr.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Adani Airport City Limited (AACL), a wholly owned subsidiary of Adani Airport Holdings Limited (AAHL), has unveiled plans to develop integrated airport cities across its network of airports, with an initial investment of more than ₹20,000 crore.

First phase

The first phase of the programme will see the development of about 22 million square feet of hospitality, retail, entertainment, convention and commercial infrastructure across airports in Mumbai, Navi Mumbai, Ahmedabad, Lucknow, Jaipur and

Puri, Iran Minister hold talks after years of curtailed trade

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

Indicative of a potential revival in energy cooperation, Union Minister for Petroleum Hardeep Singh Puri met his Iranian counterpart Mohsen Paknejad on the sidelines of the BRICS Energy Ministers’ Meeting Thursday. Describing the meeting, Mr. Puri wrote on his social media, ‘We explored opportunities to cooperate in the energy sector for a beneficial engagement.’ India halted crude purchases from Tehran in 2019 following U.S. sanctions. As per S&P Global Commodities at Sea data, India purchased 5.18 lakh barrels/day of Iranian oil in



A thaw: Puri with Paknejad on the sidelines of BRICS Energy Ministers’ Meeting, in Gurugram, Haryana. @HARDEEPSURI

2018 slowing down to 2.68 lakh barrels/day between January and May 2019 on U.S.’s temporary waiver. Indian refiners moved away from purchasing the crude until April this year when U.S. offered a temporary 30-day waiver. Kpler data show India im-

ported 1.33 lakh barrels/day of Iranian oil in April. However, the latest peace-deal between Iran and U.S. houses a waiver for “production, delivery and sale of crude oil, petroleum products and petroleum products” from Iran.

Simaero eyes \$100 mn India simulator training unit

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI

French aircraft simulator training provider Simaero is set to launch a new pilot training facility, with a planned investment of \$100 million that will enable expansion to eight full-flight simulators over the coming years. Equipped with a single Airbus A320 full-flight simulator, Simaero plans to expand capacity at its training centre in Gurugram progressively, with CEO Nicolas Moute saying the company expects to add four to six simulators over the next five years, depending on demand from airline customers.

‘MSMEs must lead India’s innovation push to achieve Viksit Bharat goal’

BL Bureau
BENGALURU

India’s micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs) will play a decisive role in determining whether the country achieves its ambition of becoming a developed economy by 2047, with policymakers and industry leaders calling for a stronger focus on innovation, design, talent and technology adoption at the fifth edition of *The Hindu BusinessLine* MSME Growth Conclave, co-powered by Central Bank of India.

Across discussions on manufacturing, electronics, skilling and entrepreneurship, a common theme rose: India can no longer rely solely on low-cost production and must move up the value chain. Setting the tone for the conclave, Karnataka Minister for Medical Education and Skill Development Dr. Sharanaprakash Rudrappa Patil urged businesses to think beyond manufacturing. “We should move from ‘Made in India’ to ‘Designed, Engineered and Owned in India’,” he said, adding India’s MSMEs would determine whether the country becomes a global innovation hub or the world’s factory floor.

Addressing the forum, B.V. Naidu, chairman of the Karnataka Digital Economy Mission (KDEM), said India is on track to become a \$32 trillion economy by 2047, but warned that achieving developed nation status would require a substantial rise in per-capita income. He argued that MSMEs would play an even greater role than large enterprises in driving economic growth because of their agility and ability to



Crucial area: Sharanaprakash Rudrappa Patil at thehindu businessline MSME Growth Conclave Bengaluru-2026. BIJOY GHOSH

innovate. Mr. Naidu also highlighted the growing importance of the digital economy, noting that Karnataka’s digital sector contributes between 35% and 40% of the state’s economy. He said government support in areas such as market access, infrastructure, financing and talent development would be crucial, particularly as smaller firms grapple with the rapid adoption of AI.

Focus on IP

That sentiment echoed through the electronics manufacturing panel, where speakers argued that India should focus on building IP and specialised capabilities rather than attempting to replicate China’s manufacturing model. “If anyone thinks we can compete with China by being cheaper, it is not the game,” said Sachin Dhruva Naik, founder and chief executive of Cuzor Labs. Sonam Motwani, founder and chief executive of Karkhana.io, noted that India still has a long way to go

Amazon to invest additional \$13 bn in AI, cloud: CEO

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Amazon CEO Andy Jassy on Thursday announced an additional investment of \$13 billion to expand AI and cloud infrastructure in India by 2030. This comes within six months of Amazon announcing \$35 billion in new investments in the country. Mr. Jassy met Prime Minister Narendra Modi earlier in the day at New Delhi and reiterated Amazon’s long-term commitment to the country.

The CEO highlighted the growing importance of India, where Amazon operated several businesses including e-commerce, AI and cloud, and entertainment among others. He also noted that the company’s India business was on a strong growth trajectory with strong customer demand, especially in e-commerce and AWS business.

“We came to India over a decade ago and have since been serving customers, sellers, developers, start-ups and enterprises through our different businesses. The response has been tremendous, with strong growth especially across our e-commerce, AI, and cloud businesses,” Mr. Jassy said.

“As we grow Amazon in India, our business priorities continue to align with India’s priorities of democratising access to AI, digitising small businesses, creating jobs, and enabling exports. We are investing over \$48 billion in the coming five years to meet the strong demand across our



Amazon CEO Andy Jassy with Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday.

business in India and to help the country achieve these priorities,” he said.

This takes Amazon’s total planned investment in expanding and supporting AI and cloud infrastructure to over \$21 billion between 2026 and 2030, establishing it as one of the largest global AI and cloud infrastructure investors in the country.

According to an Amazon communique, the investment will expand AWS data centre capacity in Mumbai and Hyderabad, giving start-ups, enterprises and government organisations access to custom AI chips, managed AI services, secure and reliable cloud technologies and developer tools to innovate faster, scale rapidly, and serve customers globally.

Amazon’s cumulative investments in India from 2010-2030 stand at over \$88 billion, as per the company. The company plans to launch over 20 new fulfilment centres and over 100 new last-mile delivery stations this year, ensuring faster and reliable deliveries nationwide, especially in tier 3 and 4 cities.

REUTERS

REUTERS

AFP

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K

The unheralded Karnataka girl trained with a borrowed pole for the two weeks; also booking their slots for the continental showpiece are Animesh (men's 200m), Harita and Unnathi (women's 200m), and Gowthami (women's 800m)

Y.B. Sarangi
BHUBANESWAR

The unheralded Sindhushree G. wrote her name in the record books with a shock win over Baranica Elangovan in the women's pole vault and qualified for the Asian Games on the second day of the National Inter-State athletics meet at the Kalinga Stadium here on Thursday.

The 25-year-old short statured Karnataka girl – who trained for two weeks with a borrowed pole from a fellow male athlete, who had purchased the equipment meant for women by mistake – relied on her endurance to thrive despite the humid conditions. She achieved the National mark of 4.25m ahead of Baranica, who couldn't improve upon her previous mark of 4.23m.

"I do 30 jumps in training. I had enough endurance," said Sindhushree, whose previous best was 4.00m in the Indian Athletics Series in Delhi in May.

Proudly holding a photo of her late father, R. Ganesh, who backed her to pursue athletics before his death in 2022, Sindhusree said, "I dedicate this to my father, who had dreamt of seeing me in India colours."

Gowthami Jayaraman
timed 2:04.17 to upset Poo-
ja Ola and secure the wo-



Nagoya calling: (clockwise) SindhuShree, Animesh, Harita and Gowthami will hope to carry on their good form into the quadrennial event and do India proud. BISWARANJAN ROUT



men's 800m crown. Animesh Kujur (20.87) made the cut for the continental show-piece in men's 200m heats before lowering it to 20.74 to win the final.

Harita Bhadra (23.55) and Unnathi Bollanda (23.65) also qualified in the women's 200m heats before taking the top two places in the final, clocking 23.14 and 23.40 respectively.

The results (finals): Men:
200m (Asiad q mark 20.88): 1. Animesh Kujur (Odi) 20.74, 2. Dondapati M. Jayaram (Odi) 20.97, 3. Jishnu Prasad P.K. (Ker) 21.18; **800m (Asiad q mark 1:48.80):** 1. Mohammed Afzal P. (Ker) 1:48.57, 2. Krishan Kumar (Har) 1:48.82, 3. Prathamesh

Tejas Shirse (13.43) set a

new meet record in men's 110m hurdles. He earned an Asiad berth and bettered his previous meet record (13.54).

The results (finals): Men:
200m (Asiad Q mark 20.88): 1. Animesh Kujur (Odi) 20.74, 2. Dondapati M. Jayaram (Odi) 20.97, 3. Jishnu Prasad P.K. (Ker) 21.18; **800m (Asiad Q mark 1:48.80):** 1. Mohammed Afsal P. (Ker) 1:48.57, 2. Krishan Kumar (Har) 1:48.82, 3. Prathamesh Deore (Mah) 1:48.89; **Discus**

(Asiad Q mark 60.13m): 1. Kirpal Singh (Cdh) 57.37m, 2. Nirbhay Singh (Har) 55.26m, 3. Arjun (Del) 54.90m; **Decathlon (Asiad Q mark 7250):** 1. Thowfeeq N. (Ker) 7276, 2. Kushal Mohide (Mah) 7251, 3. Jashbir Nayak (Od) 7131; **Half-marathon state walk (Asiad Q mark 1:25:37):** 1. Servin Sebastian (TN) 1:31:49, 2. Sachin Bohra (Utk) 1:32:10, 3. Ningthoukjunga (Man) 1:32:24, 23.40, 3. Prakruthi Roopa Rao (Kar) 23:58; **800m (Asiad Q mark 2:05.21):** 1. Gowthami Jayaraman (TN) 2:04:17, 2. Pooja Ola (Har) 2:04:37, 3. Lili Das (WB) 2:04:59; **Shot put (Asiad Q mark 16.25m):** 1. Manpreet Kaur (Har) 17.75m, Krishna Jayasankar (TN) 16.96m, 3. Srishti Vig (Del) 16.96m; **Pole vault (Asiad Q mark 4.10m):** 1. Sindhusree G. (Kar) 4.15m (NR, Old 4.23m, Baran).

Women: 200m (Asiad Q mark 23.70): 1. Harita Bhadra (Mah) 23.14, 2. Unnathi Bollanda (Kar) 4.25m (NR, Old 4.25m, Baranica Elangovan, 2026), 2. Baranica Elangovan (TN) 4.20m, 3. Nitika Akare (MP) 4.10m.

23.40, 3. Prakruthi Roopa Rao (Kar) 23.58; **800m (Asiad Q mark) 2:05.21**: 1. Gowthami Jayaraman (TN) 2:04.17, 2. Pooja Olaya (TN) 2:04.37, 3. Lili Das (WB) 2:04.59; **Shot put (Asiad Q mark 16.25m)**: 1. Manpreet Kaur (TN) 17.75m, Krishna Jayasankar (Har) 16.96m, 3. Srishti Vig (Del) 16.96m;
16.96m;
Pole vault (Asiad Q mark 4.10m): 1. Sindhuashree G. (Kar) 4.25m (NR, Old 4.23m, Baranica Elangovan, 2026), 2. Baranica Elangovan (TN) 4.20m, 3. Nitika Akare (MP) 4.10m.

Y.B. Sarangi
BHUBANESWAR



Jyoti. INSTAGRAM/JYOTIGULIABOXER

Former World under-17 champion Jyoti Gulia is delighted that her resilience has helped her win a gold medal in the China leg of the World Cup recently.

Jyoti, who got her first opportunity to compete in an international event after two years, was hungry for success.

“After I lost in the Commonwealth Games trials, I dropped down from 51kg to 48kg for the first time. I had just 20-25 days to cut down three kg. The hunger was there and I was keen to take gold whenever I got an opportunity,” Jyoti, the lone gold medalist in Guiyang City, told *The Hindu*.

"I cut down on my diet. I quit everything, ate only boiled food. I stopped having dinner, and had just a protein drink or fruits. My strength also reduced. Still, I managed to win gold."

Jyoti, coming from a batch of tough girls who secured five gold medals for India in the 2017 World under-17 championships, recalled her World Cup bouts.

"Since I was competing

LIVE TELECAST

FIFA World Cup: Unite8 Sports
1, 2 & Z5 App, 7.30 a.m. 12.30 &
5.30 a.m. (Saturday)

England vs New Zealand: 3rd Test, day 2, Sony Sports Ten 2 & LIV, 3.30 p.m.

West Indies vs Sri Lanka: 1st Test, day 2, FanCode, 7.30 p.m.

Women's T20 World Cup: Star Sports 1 & JioHotstar, 11 p.m.

TODAY, 5:30 PM



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In normal course, a contest against Ireland would fly under the radar, but this clearly isn't normal course. The winds of change in the set-up has added interest in the upcoming tours with Sooryavanshi hogging the limelight



CONCLUSION

As home care needs rise, insurance gaps widen

Doctors, geriatric care specialists and patient advocates are calling for health insurance policies to expand beyond hospitalisation and cover home-based care, which they say, has become a critical part of modern treatment and recovery

ILLUSTRATION: SAAI

The Hindu Bureau

For Srijita Basak, a resident of Kolkata, the cost of looking after her elderly parents over the past three years has run into lakhs. And there is no end in sight. “My mother had replacement surgeries on both her knees and my father has had multiple operations for his back issues after he had a fall and hurt his spine. For both, while a bulk of the surgery and hospital costs were met through insurance, none of the aftercare at home has been covered. We have incurred massive costs for home nurses, medicines, a hospital bed for home, physiotherapy and care,” said the 31-year-old, private company employee.

Srijita’s case is not unique: with India’s life expectancy having increased from 41 years in 1950 to 72 in 2024, Indians are living longer, but not necessarily healthier. India’s senior citizen population is expected to touch 347 million by 2050, and its metabolic disease burden is amongst the highest in the world, and the country accounts for 11% of the world’s road traffic accidents. Taken together, these facts mean that a significant number of citizens need health care at home, sometimes for a short period and in other cases, long-term. According to market research company IMARC Group, India’s home healthcare market was valued at \$16.3 billion in 2025 and is expected to reach \$74.57 billion by 2034. And yet, insurance models have not kept pace with these needs, home healthcare services are expensive, unregulated and often unqualified, and community healthcare services are scarce.



Healthcare and insurance systems continue to focus on acute care and hospitalisation, while chronic conditions place the greatest long-term financial and emotional burden on families. Recognition of home care as a component of holistic healthcare is essential

SRIKALA BHARATH
Geriatric psychiatrist

As healthcare increasingly shifts from hospitals to patients’ homes, doctors, geriatric care specialists and patient advocates are calling for health insurance policies to expand beyond hospitalisation and cover home-based care, which they say, has become a critical part of modern treatment and recovery.

After a hospital stay

For many, the end of the hospital signifies the end of costs. For some, however, the financial burden becomes worse after hospitalisation, says Pavithra Reddy, chief operating officer of Vayah Vikas, a Bengaluru-based organisation working with senior citizens. “Older adults recovering from strokes, fractures, surgeries or serious illnesses frequently require nursing support, physiotherapy, wound care, mobility assistance and medical equipment at home. Yet these services are rarely covered by insurance. Families often spend between ₹30,000 to ₹1 lakh a month on post-hospitalisation care.”

A caregiver supporting a family member with dementia in Karnataka said they currently pay ₹36,000 a month for a full-time attendant. “We have no choice because the caregiver gives us peace of mind, but the costs are substantial and there is virtually no insurance support,” the caregiver said.

Srikala Bharath, geriatric psychiatrist who was formerly with NIMHANS, Bengaluru, said continuity of care remains one of the weakest links in India’s healthcare system. “Healthcare and insurance systems

■ According to research, India’s home healthcare market was valued at \$16.3 billion in 2025 and is expected to reach \$74.57 billion by 2034

■ India’s health insurance architecture is built predominantly around acute hospitalisation episodes. This means that the ongoing care needs of a burgeoning elderly population are largely ignored

continue to focus on acute care and hospitalisation, while chronic conditions place the greatest long-term financial and emotional burden on families. Recognition of home care as a component of holistic healthcare is essential,” she said.

Ramani Sundaram, executive director of Dementia India Alliance, said families caring for persons with dementia face particularly high costs. “Long-term nursing support, medication management and caregiver assistance are almost entirely funded out of pocket. Home healthcare remains under insured and inadequately regulated,” she said.

India’s health insurance architecture is built predominantly around acute hospitalisation episodes. This means that the ongoing care needs of a burgeoning elderly population who might need support for home-based rehabilitation or chronic care are largely ignored.

“This is a critical gap in our health financing system which neither insurance companies nor the government has chosen to address. These problems are only going to worsen,” a Kerala-based health financing expert said.

What is offered by Indian health insurance companies for home-based care – domiciliary hospitalisation – is a specific, narrow provision offered for short-term care at home, which the treating doctor must prescribe and certify. Even with this however, insurance companies have tightened exclusion clauses and have brought in restrictions. “Many are not offering domiciliary hospitalisation cover at all because these claims are very hard to verify and there have been many fraudulent claims. Many now cap it at a percentage of the sum insured,” said Stanley Wilson, business associate, New India Assurance company.

The lack of training

The expense apart, families noted that home nurses provided through agencies are often unqualified and untrained.

When his father was diagnosed with Alzheimer’s disease, Prakash, a government employee in Thiruvananthapuram, decided to look for dedicated caregivers for him. “I wanted him to be taken care of at home. But it was not easy. I discovered that there were no qualified home nursing care providers and none of the ‘home nurses’ that I hired had any idea how to manage a dementia patient. They would all leave within two days of

being hired, complaining that my dad was a “difficult” patient and that he was “non-cooperative”. We could not make them understand that my father needed compassionate care and that he seemed to be “difficult” because he was losing his comprehension skills and memory day-by-day.”

Over the next few years, Prakash hired a string of home nurses – all of whom, he said, expected to merely help elderly people, not care for them professionally. “None of them knew how to give insulin shots or to even give medication based on the prescription,” he said.

The burden becomes even heavier when children live abroad and their elderly parents at home require care, an issue that is raising serious social concerns in many parts of the country.

Sreejaya, originally from Kerala and now in Dubai, took several months off work to care for her ailing mother-in-law, after none of the caregivers she hired proved to have any training. And her experience was similar even at a senior living facility. “The living facilities were fine, but for the care of patients like Amma, who is close to 90, has lost her eyesight to glaucoma and has a host of other ailments, they did not have professionally trained caregivers. They were also depending on agencies to supply them with “home nurses” who had no knowledge or training,” she said.

The impact

Members of families where one person requires long-term care often have to give up their jobs to care for the sick relative themselves, because outside help, even if untrained, is prohibitively expensive. This creates immense socio-economic and psychological stress, said Subarna Goswami, a senior physician and public health administrator, based in Kolkata.

Financial constraints also often force families to cut back on essential rehabilitation, nursing visits, and follow-ups, Dr. Goswami pointed out. “This compromises recovery, leading to avoidable complications like infections, permanent functional disability, and preventable hospital readmissions. It also overburdens hospital resources by driving up dependency on inpatient services. Ultimately, underinvesting in home care paradoxically spikes total healthcare costs,” Dr. Goswami added.

Home-based care can significantly reduce not only medical expenses but also the indirect costs associated with

illness. “When one family member falls sick, caregivers often lose workdays and household productivity suffers. Home care has the potential to reduce these burdens while ensuring continuity of treatment,” said U.S. Vishal Rao, group director for head and neck surgical oncology and robotic surgery at HCG Cancer Centre, Bengaluru.

What is required, said the Kerala health financing expert, is a model that blends both traditional health insurance and welfare provisions, to address the increasing long-term care needs of senior citizens, people with disabilities or conditions and injuries. Japan and Germany for instance, have long-term insurance care policies that take this into account. This is an issue that has begun to figure in policy discussions on the demographic crisis and the consequent needs of the elderly population

From a financial planning perspective, Priyanka Rana Patgiri, consultant, geriatrics at Apollo Hospitals, Chennai, pointed out, it may be advisable for families to consider adding a domiciliary floater cover to a health insurance policy.

While post-operative extended convalescence is mostly covered post major surgeries conducted in hospitals, utilisation of this remains limited as these work mostly on a reimbursement, not cashless basis, said Arti Malik, chief technology officer, Universal Sampo General Insurance. However, more people now want cover for both active hospitalisations and extended convalescence and recovery, she noted. When it comes to training, Ms. Sreejaya said that there was an urgent need for caregivers who are well-versed in dealing with patients, able to understand doctors’ instructions and manage aspects like patient hygiene, dressing wounds, preventing bed sores, checking blood sugar and pressure, checking for vitals etc.

Home care organisations face problems of shortage of staff as there is often no dignity of labour, noted Dr. Patgiri. Training of staff, proper communication and better salaries would help address such issues, she said, adding that effective home care should go beyond medical treatment to include assistance with daily activities, social engagement and caregiver support. “Accreditation of home care organisations by the National Accreditation Board for Hospitals and Healthcare (NABH) will pave the way

for greater standardisation of care. This can help improve the quality of care and achieve maintainable benchmarks,” she stressed.

Community care

Going forward, a community-based model integrating healthcare, social support and care giving services will be essential to help older adults age with dignity at home. Hospital admissions in older adults are often diagnosed in the emergency room, but they begin at home months earlier, Dr. Patgiri pointed out.

In this regard, Kerala, which leads the country both with the highest prevalence of chronic, non-communicable diseases and with top-performing public health infrastructure, is now taking the first step towards creating a brigade of professional nursing care service providers by launching a government-approved six-month ‘Caregiver Certificate Course’, in government and private nursing colleges, as well as in selected hospitals, aimed at ensuring professional care for those in need and providing dignified employment.

In the private sector, an NGO, Self Employed Women’s Association (SEWA) has joined hands with palliative care organisation, Pallium India, to train women in giving professional palliative/nursing care to those who require it. SEWA’s Secretary, Sonia George says that the first batch of 30 women are now rendering professional caregivers’ service in hospitals and homes and that the demand for the service has been so huge that they have not been able to keep pace. Such an initiative could be modelled across the country

Apart from rehailing insurance models, policies from the government for training of workers to build a skilled cadre, regulations for wage guarantees and rules to ensure the safety and dignity of both patients and those providing care, financial aid for family caregivers and setting up provisions for respite care could all go a long way towards helping families and societies care for their aged and disabled, say experts.

The problem is growing. India’s financial and care models need to catch up.

(With inputs from C. Maya in Kerala, Afshan Yasmeen in Karnataka, Shrabana Chatterjee in West Bengal, Serena Josephine M. in Tamil Nadu and Bindu Shajan Perappadan in Delhi.) (health@thehindu.co.in)

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Amount approved by ADB to boost bamboo industry in northeast

42.2 in \$ million. The Asian Development Bank has approved a USD 42.2 million small-expenditure financing facility to develop the bamboo industry in India's northeastern States. It will support community-based projects that enhance the usage of bamboo resources across Assam, Manipur, Meghalaya, Mizoram, Nagaland, and Tripura. PTI

Number of ships that sailed through Strait of Hormuz since June 23

57 Some 57 ships carrying an estimated 1,100 seafarers have transited the Strait of Hormuz since June 23 under a United Nations evacuation plan launched this week. These are the first numbers to be released by the U.N.'s International Maritime Organization for the initiative, which will enable hundreds of ships with some 11,000 seafarers to leave the Strait. REUTERS

IAS, DANICS officers transferred by Delhi government

60 In a major administrative reshuffle, the Delhi government has transferred 60 IAS and DANICS cadre officers, with immediate effect. According to the Services department orders issued on Wednesday, the additional chief secretary (ACS) of the Social Welfare Department will also handle the additional charge of the Women and Child Development department. PTI

Forest fire incidents across Maharashtra during 2023-24

5,100 More than 5,100 forest fire incidents were reported across Maharashtra during 2023-24, affecting 11,580.707 hectares of forest land, Forest Minister Ganesh Naik informed the State Legislative Assembly on Thursday. He was responding to questions raised by MLAs from Shiv Sena (UBT) and BJP over forest fires. PTI

Trees felled illegally in Maharashtra in the last five years

3.5 lakh. As many as 3.5 lakh trees were felled illegally in forest areas in Maharashtra in the last five years, Forest Minister Ganesh Naik informed the State Legislative Assembly on Thursday. The trees chopped illegally included 1.24 lakh teak trees, the Minister said, adding that it amounted to a loss of ₹30 crore to the State exchequer. PTI
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Revisiting India's ultrasound laws

Technological shifts and rising need for community-based cancer screening suggest that regulatory frameworks should adapt to distinguish between different use cases of ultrasound. An amendment to the PCPNDT Act could legalise community-based ultrasound using a high-frequency linear probe, as it will not impact sex determination

FULL CONTEXT

Parth Sharma
Senthil Kumar A.R.

Mrs. Janki (name changed), a 45-year-old woman, came to a health camp organised in rural Assam with a complaint of a painless breast lump. She had noticed the lump three months earlier and reported that it had gradually increased in size. On examination, the doctor suspected breast cancer and advised her to visit a cancer hospital located two hours away for further evaluation. “But I have no pain. The hospital is so far away. There is nobody to come with me to the hospital,” Mrs. Janki said. Despite repeated counselling, she refused to seek further care.

Three months later, Janki finally presented to the hospital. By then, she had developed a large, bleeding mass in her breast. She was diagnosed with advanced stage breast cancer and died six months later.

Technological advances, like portable ultrasound machines, have made it possible to bring cancer diagnostics, such as ultrasound imaging and ultrasound-guided biopsies, closer to people's homes. This machine could, perhaps, have given Mrs. Janaki a diagnosis at her doorstep. However, India's Pre-Conception and Pre-Natal Diagnostic Techniques (PCPNDT) Act treats the movement of an ultrasound machine outside a registered facility as a serious offence, with penalties that can include a minimum of three months' non-bailable imprisonment.

Provisions of the PCPNDT Act

The PCPNDT Act was introduced in 1994 in response to a sharp decline in the child sex ratio in India, driven by a strong societal preference for male children and the growing misuse of technologies such as ultrasonography for prenatal sex determination, followed by selective abortion of female fetuses. Abortion of female fetuses became more evident from the 1980s, with the increasing availability of imaging technologies, raising serious ethical, demographic, and public health concerns. The legislation, therefore, aimed not only to prevent the misuse of medical technology but also to address the deeper issue of gender discrimination.

The law mandates registration of all genetic clinics, ultrasound centres, and laboratories and strictly prohibits the communication or disclosure of the sex of the foetus. It prescribes detailed record-keeping, monitoring mechanisms, and penalties to ensure compliance.

Under this Act, the purchase of an ultrasound machine is not a routine commercial transaction but a tightly-regulated process. A clinic or hospital must first be registered with the district government as a genetic clinic or imaging centre before acquiring a machine. Purchasing one without prior registration is illegal. Manufacturers or dealers are required to verify the buyer's credentials and obtain a written undertaking that the machine will not be used for sex determination. The sale must be documented with invoice details that match the registered centre, and the transaction is reported to the authorities for monitoring.

Once installed, the machine must remain at the approved location, its details must be recorded in official registers, and strict documentation,



Expanding access: Portable, handheld ultrasound devices can make it technically feasible to bring diagnostic services closer to patients' homes. GETTY IMAGES

including patient records for every scan, must be maintained.

Impact of PCPNDT Act

Following the introduction of the PCPNDT Act, the sex ratio at birth in India has shown a gradual improvement at the national level. While this improvement cannot be conclusively attributed to the introduction of the Act, several unintended consequences can be directly attributed to it.

Evidence suggests that families whose first child is a girl tend to have more children in an effort to have a son, compared to families with a firstborn boy. Following restrictions on prenatal sex selection, families experienced a 25% higher child mortality rate among firstborn girls relative to firstborn boys. This could be explained by the decline in parental investment in health, particularly among girls. Fertility also increased in these families, indicating a shift toward having more children when sex selection was not an option. Having a larger number of children also led to dilution of resources, likely reducing overall investment per child. Similar patterns were observed in education as gender disparities widened. These effects were more pronounced among poorer, rural households that were more affected by the restrictions, as they could not afford illegal services to abort the child.

Recent reports indicate that sex-selective practices continue despite decades of legal prohibition. In October 2025, authorities uncovered an illegal racket in Karnataka where organised networks were carrying out prenatal sex determination and facilitating abortions, often targeting vulnerable women from rural areas. Similar crackdowns across different States show that such activities are frequently conducted outside formal health systems, using portable ultrasound devices, informal providers, and covert arrangements to evade regulation.

The issue is not confined to India. Reports from the United Kingdom indicates that son preference may persist among some diaspora communities as well. Reports have also raised concerns that families of Indian origin may be engaging in sex-selective practices even in

settings with stricter oversight, highlighting the deep-rooted nature of gender bias that transcends national boundaries.

Taken together, these patterns underscore a critical limitation of legislative approaches. While laws such as the PCPNDT Act establish an essential regulatory framework, they are insufficient on their own to drive social change.

The case for reform

Available evidence suggests that the PCPNDT Act has not fully achieved its intended objectives and may, in some contexts, have had unintended adverse effects. Additionally, fear of legal repercussions and stringent regulatory requirements has had a chilling effect on service provision.

Moreover, The PCPNDT Act has not kept pace with advances in ultrasound technology. Portable, handheld ultrasound devices, often connected to smartphones or tablets, make it technically feasible to bring diagnostic services closer to patients' homes, which is particularly relevant for early cancer detection in underserved areas. However, the use of such devices at the community level is currently illegal in India.

Modern high-frequency probes used for applications such as cancer detection and the assessment of other superficial conditions cannot be used for foetal sex determination, yet remain subject to the same regulatory restrictions, limiting access to essential diagnostic care.

Recent developments in artificial intelligence (AI) further strengthen the case for a more nuanced regulatory approach. AI-enabled ultrasound systems can assist with image acquisition and interpretation, and in some configurations generate automated reports based on pattern recognition without requiring full image storage or display. Such technologies could enable safe, purpose-specific use of ultrasound for diagnostic applications while substantially reducing the risk of misuse for foetal sex determination.

Recent research has also demonstrated the potential of AI in improving access to reliable ultrasonography. In a pilot study,

portable ultrasound scans performed by individuals with minimal training were combined with AI to identify suspicious breast lesions with high accuracy, correctly flagging all confirmed cancer cases. This suggests that AI-assisted ultrasound could enable frontline health workers to assess patients with breast lumps, refer those with suspicious findings for further evaluation, and reassure those with benign conditions.

For countries such as India, where access to specialist radiologists and diagnostic imaging remains uneven, especially in rural areas where nearly 70% of the population resides, such innovations could substantially improve the timely assessment and treatment of symptomatic patients. Earlier diagnosis and referral have the potential to reduce breast cancer mortality while expanding access to care in rural and underserved areas. This contrasts with many Western countries, where breast cancer control strategies rely more heavily on mammographic screening programmes that detect tumours before symptoms appear but require considerably greater resources and infrastructure.

Serving a greater need

These technological shifts and the rising need for community-based cancer screening in view of the high cancer burden in India suggest that regulatory frameworks need to adapt to distinguish between different use cases of ultrasound. An amendment to the Act could make community-based ultrasound using a high-frequency linear probe legal, as it will not impact sex determination. Additionally, the Act should incorporate provisions addressing emerging technologies, including AI-enabled and safeguarded USG imaging systems designed to prevent the determination or disclosure of foetal sex, irrespective of intent.

(Dr. Parth Sharma is a community physician working in the department of preventive oncology and public health at Cachar Cancer Hospital and Research Centre. Dr. Senthil Kumar A.R. is a consultant radiologist and former director of the department of radiology, Aberdeen Royal Infirmary, U.K. Views are personal.)

THE GIST

▼ The PCPNDT Act was introduced in 1994 to curb prenatal sex determination and the selective abortion of female fetuses in response to a declining child sex ratio.

▼ The law has not kept pace with advances in ultrasound technology, including portable handheld devices that can bring diagnostic services closer to patients' homes.

▼ For countries such as India, where access to specialist radiologists and diagnostic imaging remains uneven, such innovation could aid early cancer detection, particularly in underserved areas.

